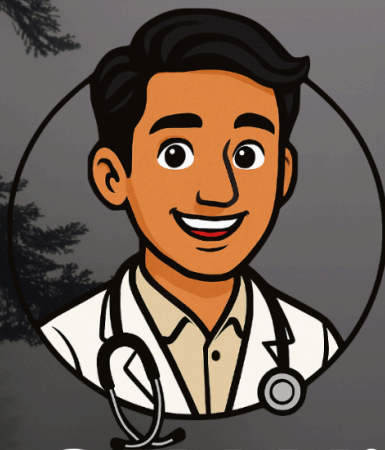




ROHAN'S GAMSAT

GAMSAT S2

EXPERT ESSAY COLLECTION

**25 Essays To Conquer
GAMSAT Section 2**

Contents

I *Essays on Society* (T A S K A)

FOURTEEN ESSAYS

- 01 Globalisation
- 02 Clicktivism
- 03 Meritocracy
- 04 Consumerism
- 05 Inequality
- 06 Crime
- 07 Technology
- 08 Justice
- 09 Politics
- 10 Rich & Poor
- 11 Consumerism #2
- 12 Welfare

13 Cancel Culture

14 Disillusionment

II *Essays on the Self*

ELEVEN ESSAYS

(TASK B)

15 Religion

16 Cynicism

17 Travel

18 Youth

19 Fantasy & Comfort

20 Love

21 Identity

22 Happiness

23 Laughter

24 Food

25 Forgiveness

Globalisation

Planes in the sky and ships in the seas.

Images synonymous with integration of commerce and trade across the world. This wave of advancement in transportation and communication, which arose from the 20th century Industrialisation, gave rise to an emerging phenomenon of global integration. Yet globalisation, which grew out of Neoliberalism, has become an ideology of its own, where a singular focus on economic unification across the world has distracted us from more significant interpersonal, local issues that affect us deeply in today's Western societies. Ironically, the international pursuit of economic wealth through the vehicle of globalisation is dividing us more than ever and addressing such social, interpersonal issues would truly connect us in a 'collective consciousness'.

Globalisation, in its attempt to break down economic barriers across the world through free trade, has ultimately divided the world on class levels more than ever and exacerbated inequality across the Western world. Free trade seeks to promote the exchange of goods and services across national borders and thus enable consumers and firms to access wider markets. This Ricardian idea of economic utopia where we all have access to goods and services from across the world does appear to benefit us all, but it clearly ignores the capacity for a global capitalist society to operate in a distorted zero-sum game. Unlike conventional game theory, capitalism induces hundreds of losers for each winner. For one multinational corporation that expands into a new country, hundreds of small businesses that cannot compete must shut down. To this extent it seems to me that Globalisation brings about an inevitable exacerbation of existing inequality in our societies. Those that

enjoy the greatest benefits from the game of Globalisation are those that have the capacity and resources to expand to international markets, whilst smaller businesses that lack the ability to grow must remain local and fend off incoming global giants. Lower income, smaller businesses fail and thus comes a wave of unemployment and a perpetual cycle of economic disaster for the lower classes emerges. Meanwhile however, the elites that own and operate the multinationals that benefit the most from globalisation earn riches upon riches as their immense scale and brand recognition destroys any and all local competition. As such, globalisation has brought with it a relentless wave of deepening inequality both within countries but also between countries themselves. In Australia, the top 10% of income earners hold more than half of all wealth in Australia - compared to just 42% in the 1980s. This all arises as a symptom of the obsessive pursuit of world domination and wealth that has become synonymous with globalisation. And so it seems to me that Globalisation, whilst being efficient in growing and supporting income growth for the high income earners of our economy - has regressed on the work of modern liberalism and has induced a wave of worsening inequality for the lower class. In its destructive singular focus on economic profits and expansion in trade, the commodification that necessarily emerges out of globalisation of our Western economies has blinded us from and exacerbates deeper social issues which not only pose more significant threats to our species but would act as a more appropriate vehicle for global unity and harmony. As our Western economies continue to expand and produce at mass scale, with the sole intention of creating economic value, we overlook the environmental consequences this can have. Neoliberal proponents of globalisation imagine a world where politics and economics are separated in the pursuit for the global extension of markets. To obey the rational 'laws' of the market and to insulate, as much as possible, from the petty irrationalities of politics is what would bring about a peaceful and prosperous global economy. But indeed, this singular focus ignores rising social and political issues which pose dangerous threats to the marketisation of

the world itself; such as climate change. Mass scale production, transportation and overconsumption has exacerbated carbon emissions and hence deepened the need for coordinated climate action. Ironically, despite ignoring these growing en-

vironmental concerns, globalisation is uniquely threatened by climate change itself the conception of ‘limitless’ economic growth clearly contradicts the realisation of Earth’s geophysical limits. This implies that globalisation, whilst inducing an age of mass growth and innovation, is far from being ‘efficient’ on a political and social basis. A more efficient alternative of globalisation is one that would harness our connectivity as a global species to cooperate and address issues like climate change. And whilst our connectivity has brought about improvements like the Paris Agreement, ultimately our failures to meet the goals and objectives laid out in these treaties is forgiven because of fears that it may constrict economic growth. Whilst it’s true that the mass marketisation that has come with Globalisation has improved product and service offerings for consumers in advanced Western economies, our overall quality of life is tracking lower due to these deeper, plaguing issues. Hence it appears to be inaccurate and unclear that globalisation is truly as efficient as Lamy put it. The connection of global economies is a trend that emerged out of the rise of Neoliberalism and a primary focus on the marketisation of the world around us in modern Western societies. Globalisation would bring growth they said. It would change our lives for the better they said. Take our living standards to the next level, they said. Yet, a fixation with economic efficiency and ‘productivity’ has thus limited our perceptions of the consequences of globalisation. It seems to me that globalisation has led to quality-of-life improvements, especially in the domain of consumption and technology. But on the level of the self, anxieties and concerns that emerge from the exacerbation of the climate crisis outweigh these potential benefits. Globalisation, and the implied relaxation of regulation and nation states is causing our existing societal wounds in the Western world to bleed more. Hence, as the emerging generation in this increasingly globalised world, it’s imperative that we consider ways to truly make our Western societies more efficient in all realms of life by not neglecting the exacerbation of wider social, environmental, and interpersonal issues.

Clicktivism

Click. Tap. Press.

For those who live through the ubiquitous social media all around, these actions have been naturalised as elements of our waking day. Unparalleled access to short, bite-sized content and the ability to connect with anyone across the world are few of the many revolutionary impacts of social media. And yet emerging out of a political era fuelled by deep passion from the progressive youth, social media is increasingly being seen as an opportunity for wider social change. With its virality across the contemporary West, the centrality of social media makes it appear as though we can make real social change through these platforms. In reality however, clicktivism serves as a medium through which many can ‘signal’ their virtue on pertaining social issues and, in fact in many cases it furthers and worsens social issues at hand.

Real social change is fuelled by activism which necessitates a degree of sacrifice and physical effort. Social change, throughout history has been a process by which real people take real action to affect real change. Mahatma Gandhi’s Salt March in Southeast India in the 1930s for example was an inspiring act to galvanise the Indian people and revolt against the brutal regime of Colonial Britain. This is what, many of us, would term activism. Yet today with the emergence of social media there appears to be a growing narrative that activism, in the way that we’ve traditionally conceived of it, can be easily equated with the idea of clicktivism; tweeting, posting and sharing news items to one’s account to appear personally invested in social issues. Yet what distinguishes activism from clicktivism is the real sacrifice and commitment that is necessitated. What inspires us about

Gandhi's salt march is not the fact that he is merely complaining about a relevant social issue in 1930s India, but rather that he is marching, unfed and unclothed, which makes it worth paying attention to. It seems to me that it is this sacrifice which in fact captivates the imagination of millions across the globe to pay attention to an activist's revolt. Activism has no doubt been crucial throughout Western history and much of our development in the recognition and embellishment of human rights has much to do with its achievement. Yet today it takes a new form. And the emerging question is whether, or not, this modern form of clicktivism can align with it. Clicktivism does not fuel real social change, it merely acts as a platform for individual's to "signal" their virtue. Emerging hashtags of "save Iran" for example, has been popularly used by many young social media users across the West to convey their sympathy with the seemingly authoritarian regime of contemporary Iran. This, to me, is a prominent example of clicktivism, not activism. It appears quite impossible to consider the mere act of flag-waiving to signal to friends, family and peers of one's sympathy as a form of activism. Surely, it seems to me, an individual in the West with sub-1000 followers on Instagram who shares something like this on their story does not expect this to activate actual social change. It appears to me preposterous that the leader of the authoritarian regime in Iran sees an twitter post in Australia and decides to stop persecuting the persecuted. So really, the sharing of such messages, whilst disguised as spreading solidarity, end up being quite self-serving in nature. The main benefit, it seems to me, of sharing such a post as a form of clicktivism is merely to inform and signal to one's followers that, "I am aware of this social issue and I am compassionate enough to share my support for the cause". Whilst viral hashtags such as #metoo have helped catalyse real social change, it was more so the actual physical persecution of Harvey Weinstein which enacted real justice for the victims of his crimes. Yet for the most part, the emergence of clicktivism as a form of supposedly accelerating social change seems unconvincing to me and but part of a way to propel one's social standing and

impression. Indeed, in this way, social media acts merely as a tool to invoke our truly 'self serving nature' as discussed by 19th century British philosopher Thomas Hobbes. We are, after all, fairly selfish creatures.

That activism has been an instrumental role in the development of Western history is unquestionable. In fact, the philosophy of liberalism which resides in the heart of Western identity, was formed out of the French Revolution. Yet today there is a growing trend which recognises clicktivism, the display of support for a social issue on social media, as a valid form of activism. This is, it appears to me, to underplay the role of activism. To suggest that social media can be a tool to fuel and spread social messages is an alternative viewpoint which appears more modest and reasonable. It's growing role as the ubiquitous platform for social discourse is only evolving. But to equate thus far the role of clicktivism and activism is to disrespect the sacrifices and effort of our ancestors. Click, tap and press. It's not enough.

Meritocracy

Work hard, play hard.

Well, actually, work hard and reap the benefits of what a capitalistic society has to offer. Indeed, in the contemporary West, citizens are heavily rewarded for their exploits in the economy. Those that play the capitalist game, win society's rewards. To that extent, contemporary Western society has developed a somewhat restrictive obsession with the idea that prosperity and reward should be reserved only for those who are willing to work for and earn it. Yet, in the way that it was conceived, it appears that recent shifts to a more barbaric and unconstrained version of capitalism, that have coincided with neoliberal ideology and mass marketisation, are damaging to the very identity of the West. Indeed, the West often boasts its recent history in being heralded as the birthplace for democracy, liberalism and equality. Yet with the recent flourishing of the contemporary unbridled capitalism, it appears our obsession with meritocracy, hard work and wealth accumulation has distorted traditional values. Where once we upheld the individual, we now uphold the market. Long live the market.

Capitalism in the contemporary West thrives off unequal meritocracy. For those who regard wealth accumulation and success in a capitalist setting as commendable, entrepreneur Bill Gates receives significant praise. As a mere teenager growing up in Suburban America, he was able to combine his passion and talent for technology with a hunger and desire for success to build Microsoft, one of the world's largest companies, into a global behemoth. And it is stories such as Bill Gates which are recounted. Put your head down, work hard and the world is your oyster. On the face of it, it seems brilliant. In fact, this kind of meritocratic belief

is what galvanises the “American Dream” or the widespread Western dogma that any level of wealth is accessible to any individual. So long as they work for it. Yet, in an increasingly neoliberal Western economy, we are quickly realising that it isn’t so simple. An obsession with wealth generation and capital growth surely upholds and praises the success of Bill Gates, Jeff Bezos and Elon Musk, but it fails to address a vast majority of the population who are not so capable. In fact, for those who simply are unable to work 100 hour work weeks, the American Dream is locked away. With neoliberalism has come widespread innovation and cultivation of a belief that prosperity is within arm’s reach. That is unnegotiable. Yet, in enabling such meritocratic processes and policies to thrive, contemporary Western governments have abandoned their once central role of providing a safety net. Company tax rates across the West are dropping, to supposedly incentivise and reward multinational corporations to generate more revenue. In turn, governments have less taxation revenue and play an increasingly limited role in redistributing income for those on the lowest rung of the ladder. We fuel the rich and we drain the poor. This has become, the story of modern capitalism.

A more tempered and balanced version of meritocracy is needed if the contemporary West wants to remain faithful to its traditional values. The Western world has long been built on unifying principles of liberalism, equality, and democracy. First espoused in the Declaration of Rights of Man and after the French Revolution, liberal ideals of individualism and freedom spread through Western Europe, USA, and the rest of the Commonwealth. These principles gave birth to “inalienable” human rights which were codified in both the US Constitution and the United Nations Declaration of Human Rights. Indeed, going even further back than this, came a principle of equality and egalitarianism that stemmed from Judeo-Christian principles that, “Humans were made in the image and likeness of God”. Thus, despite roadblocks with oppressive slavery and colonialism, the Western world, especially post 18th century,

blossomed into a civilisation that aimed to uphold the individual as the centre-piece of society. Naturally, capitalism, in the way that it was conceived of by classical liberal theorist Adam Smith, would be a platform that would enable individuals to flex their freedom to produce, freedom to sell and freedom to choose. In

turn, a certain level of inequality was inevitable. Yet what the classical liberals upheld, as corroborated by John Stuart Mill, was that whilst government should play a limited role, there was a role, nonetheless. When markets failed to preserve individuals' freedoms, then government should intercede. Yet today, in the neoliberal contemporary West, governments are not even willing to do that. Freedom to shelter and livelihood is found across human rights charters across the West, yet even still, more than 8% of the Western population still lives homeless. And the right to healthcare and medical treatment is locked behind excessively expensive pay walls in the US. If you want access to the best medical professionals in America, you better hope you've got a treasure chest inside your bank vault. It seems to me that somewhere along the line, in the late 20th century, the West lost sight of its core values and tenets. I suppose, in attempting to defeat the growing Communist threat that was steadily knocking down the "dominos" of Eastern Europe and Southeast Asia, the West lost track. Instead, those governments in the US and UK led by Reagan and Thatcher devolved into ultra-capitalistic, neoliberal regimes. The individual was beheaded. Long live the market.

That meritocracy has catalysed significant economic development in recent Western history is apparent. Leading innovation, rapid economic growth, higher living standards. Life has gotten better. But not for us all. Whilst the middle and upper classes have surely benefitted from such change, the lower classes have been left behind. Rising inequality in the West is seen by some as a positive signal of incentives and rampant innovation. Yet what I see is millions of individuals stranded on the streets on a freezing Winter's eve. Millions unable to pay for their child's surgery at the hospital. Long live the king they once said. Long live the individual screamed the French revolutionaries. Long live the market they say now. `

Consumerism

Earn, Spend, Sleep. The monotonous three facets of a consumer's life.

In the contemporary Western world, individuals were once perceived as citizens who hold an inherently valuable role in liberal democracies. To that extent, our value and significance arose not out of a sort of Protestant reliance on our actions and outcomes, but rather through our being as humans itself. We were, it seemed, valuable for who we were and not for who we may become. Yet more recently, the pervasive capitalist ideology of neoliberalism has somewhat corrupted the foundational emphasis on individual freedom and liberty. Where once the vigour of liberal philosophy upheld each and every individual as a citizen, we are now viewed as mere consumers. Brandished as “consumers”, our worth is quantified and not inherently justified as it once was. Instead, our worth stems from our ability to contribute to economic growth, to spend and take in the commercialised world around us and to earn money ourselves. The essence of the West lies in its conception of individuals as citizens that are integral to a functioning liberal democracy. Emerging out of archaic economic structures of feudalism in Middle Ages Europe and fairly oppressive monarchical structures, 18th century liberalism blossomed as an ideology for the people, rather than the elites. To that extent, the egalitarian philosophy that has so often been intertwined with conceptions of equality, democracy and freedom began to take shape across the continent. It started with the revolts in the French Revolution, but this kind of transformation took hold across Europe within but a few years. It was within this setting that a political philosophy that so fervently advocated for individual rights and freedom began to take hold in Europe. Liberalism. And with this emphasis

on the individual, instead of the collective, came a wave of human rights, first codified in the Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen in France. Thus, it was within liberalism that individuals were finally conceived of as citizens. That is, as active participants in the political process, rather than mere bystanders who had to soak up and accept whatever oppressive political regime happened to govern the land at the time. With this growth of liberal democracy came a gradual embellishment of individualism and, as Immanuel Kant described, “Individuals are an end in of themselves”. Democratic governments appeared across Europe and individuals who in another life may have been pushed into a life of drudgery and oppression, such as statesman Winston Churchill, now had the capability to be launched into the most powerful positions in the country. Indeed, liberalism, whilst carving out some level of economic disparity and environmental damage through mass capitalism, gave birth to a set of rights and fortuity that the mass population never before did. Preceded by more inequal and unjust social structures, individuals now had worth. They were citizens. Citizens of democracy.

Yet in the contemporary West, pervasive neoliberal ideology has redefined the individual’s social role as consumers, not citizens. In response to the emerging Communist states of Eastern Europe and China, the Western world was on the brink of collapse. In response, the West responded with an ideology of their own, neoliberalism. Emerging out of hyper- marketisation and deregulation in the 1980s with UK’s Thatcher and US’s Reagan governments, the West’s solution to Communism was simply to double-down on it’s capitalist roots. In turn, commerce and marketisation has infiltrated not just traditional markets, but it has instead become a ubiquitous behemoth which overwhelms all facets of life. Tinder, for example, serves as a platform to meet new people and date but if a premium version, “Tinder Gold” is available for a couple hundred dollars a year. With this, you can “truly find love” and get matched up with the “best dates”. Whatever that even means. Turn

on the NBA, and each free throw, each team and each stadium is advertised and endorsed by some American company. As individuals, we are no longer respected as citizens of the West that hold an inherent right to democratic process. Instead, we’re bombarded with advertisements from companies in every single as-

pect of our lives. Further, our conceptions of social worth and status come not from admirable acts we may do as citizens, but instead from how much of the consumerism cool aide we can drink. We're praised and admired for our \$3,000 Italian bespoke suits, \$500 sneakers, and designer handbags. Our worth is inextricably tied to our tendency to spend and consume. Consumerism has become the monster we simply cannot escape. It seems, today, that we are all cash junkies. And another Amazon order is our next hit.

The Western world enjoys proverbially giving itself a round of applause for the monumental strides in human rights it has led. Inevitably, much of this comes from citizens of liberal democracies, making their voices heard on significant issues and taking advantage of their inherent value to society. Yet more recently, with a surge in economic pragmatism and consumerism in the West, our role as citizens has evolved. We are, inevitably, becoming consumers before citizens. Of course, our nations are still democratic to the extent that regular elections are held to decide upon our next leaders. Democracy as a functioning political system is not dead. In fact, there are more democracies across the world than ever before. But what is dying, is the spirit of democracy. The West once saw democracy and liberalism as the beacons of its civilisation. Yet it seems a cataclysmic shift is on the horizon. The consumer will, it appears, supplant the citizen.

Inequality

The land of the free and home of the brave.

The nine-worded phrase that so commonly describes the US, and to that extent the wider West. Or does it. Indeed, built upon its foundation as a liberal democracy, the West has, over the past 300 years, developed with principles of individuality and freedom. In fact, it is these principles which have situated the West as the beacon for human rights across the world. Yet more recently, a more devious kind of “neoliberalism” has sought to bring capitalist and the pursuit of wealth to the forefront of our world. In fact, neoliberalism as the pervasive ideology of the contemporary West, has significantly worsened economic inequality and the disparity between classes in society. Ironically, it is this kind of inequality which has actually sought to disarm many individuals in the West of their supposed individuality. Therefore, the unbridled capitalism which characterises today’s Western economic landscape is effectively destroying the very foundations of individual liberty and freedom upon which the West itself is built on. Western civilisation was built on principles of individuality and liberalism. Emerging out of the triumphant overthrowing of the French monarchy in the 18th century, also known as the French Revolution, the Western world embraced a new set of principles often collectively regarded as liberalism. Where once the monarchs and Lords of the nation states owned country and land through feudalistic economic practises, classical liberalism sought to protect and uphold the value of each and every individual. This was echoed in the sentiment of 18th century French philosopher Immanuel Kant’s words, “The individual is now an end in of themselves”. What developed from there was a type of sacred upholding of the value of the individual, further codified in the US constitution and later, in the

United Nations Declaration of Human Rights. Indeed, part of this notion of liberalism and individualism was the expectation that each and every individual had a level of freedom that previously only granted to Monarchs and high-ranking nobility. This idea was summarised in John Stuart Mill's "Harm Principle", which clarified this as the capability for each individual to have the freedom to whatever he or she may please, so long as it does not harm another individual or compromise their own freedom. Thus, classical liberalism took its roots across the US and Western Europe across the 18th and 19th centuries and lay the bedrock for the democratic institutions that still stand strong across the West. Despite atrocities in colonialism and the suppression of rights for racial and gender minorities, the West stood strong in invoking mass economic development and therein creating an emerging middle class which gave wealth and opportunity to a large portion of the population that was previously in poverty. It is upon these foundations from which the West developed its dominance over the world across these two centuries and truly it's these very principles that many Americans, for example, often cite as being the reason for their being, "the greatest country on earth". Despite shortcomings, one thing is for sure. This period finally allowed the West to realise that we are, after all, individuals.

The unrestrained capitalism that exists in the contemporary West is destroying individuality and liberalism. In response to emerging Communism from the Soviet Union and the East in the mid 20th century, the West responded by doubling down onto capitalism. This gave birth to an insidious ideology of their own, neoliberalism. Born out of the heavy deregulation and mass marketisation of Reagan's US and Thatcher's UK in the 1970s, neoliberalism spread across the West and began to orient all aspects of daily life through the lens of capitalism. Granted, these policies led to a seismic shift in economic revitalisation and development and catalysed mass technological innovation as well. Yet despite all this, somewhere along the

line, Western government's lost track of what the liberalism in neoliberalism meant. In fact, unbridled capitalism in the contemporary West is characterised by a set of economic policies which serve to reward the rich and punish the poor, through the lens of meritocracy. The safety net which characterised policies of

Modern Liberal governments of the early 20th century, like Roosevelt in the US, now became an afterthought. Thus, throughout the West inequality has worsened significantly in the past 50 years. In particular, Australia's Gini Coefficient, an economic measurement of inequality, has deteriorated over 10% since the 1990s. As such, the neoliberal capitalist West of the 21st century, which serves the corporations and punishes the individual, has created a kind of distorted zero-sum game. The victory of one corporation is often at the compromise of hundreds of small businesses losing out. Thus, it seems to me that the focus of the Western politics in upholding neoliberalism has shifted its lens. The pursuit of wealth and focus on markets has supplanted the individual as the foremost priority in society. Despite naming it, "neoliberalism", there seems to me very little about the current hyper-capitalist political narratives around the West which truly uphold liberal principles. Our freedoms as individuals only exist to the extent to which they serve economic growth and consumption. We once loved the individual. Now, we love the markets.

Indeed, the philosophy of liberalism has characterised the West considerably over the past 300 years. From contributing the devolvement of feudalism and suppressive monarchies, to the building up of human rights, liberalism has been the very heart of the West. Yet in its attempt to respond to collectivist politics in the East, 20th century Western governments invoked policies which have, ironically, destroyed the very notion of the individual being at the centre of society. The inequality and economic discrepancy it bring can of course contribute to innovation and competition, but without a clear safety net and insistence of government action, it feels like the focus on the individual is losing strength. The attraction for wealth is surely as great as ever due to the commodified world in which we found ourselves. Yet despite all this, it's integral to the healthiness of the Western world that we find our feet and recall what once made us great. To recognise that we are, most of us, cash junkies, is to realise the overwhelming influence capitalism plays. Yet we were, once upon a time, freedom junkies. And it was liberalism that gave us our most invigorating hit.

Crime

The heavy hammer of justice strikes the impoverished and empowers the financier.

Inherent to the relative stability and development of Western liberal democracies over the past half-millennium has been the reliance on a consistent and just legal system. Liberalism itself posits the need for a heavy-handed legal system to protect and uphold the “sacred” value of the individual as the philosophy itself posits. Yet in the contemporary West, the system of justice has been corrupted by the sadistic impulses of unbridled, neoliberal capitalism. Where once the liberal justice system upheld the inherent rights of the impoverished, it is today at the mercy of a society-wide fixation on meritocracy, wealth accumulation and consumerism. It thus appears to me that the Western legal system has learned to accommodate unethical and illegal activity so long as it is within the overarching pursuit of unbridled capitalism. The Western justice system is only as strong as the ethical and moral values of the citizens that it seeks to protect. The Westminster legal system that is seen even today in the UK and Australia has foundations in Judeo-Christian scripture and ethic. Naturally, as Christianity became the dominant religious force throughout Europe across the Middle Ages, its ethical systems, grounded in the gospels of Jesus Christ and his disciples shaped the ethical compass of most citizens at the time. Thus, despite our tribalistic and primitive instincts, murder became outlawed. Stealing became illegal. Homosexuality became criminal. Indeed, the development of liberalism itself, in the way that it was conceived by Kant and Mill, stemmed from a very Christian belief in the individual. Christianity was about an individual’s faith and commitment to God. And thus, the individual became sacred. Yet as Western history pro-

gressed past the French revolution, Victorian era and an insurgence of progressive modernism, our ethical and moral values evolved. Embodying the very purpose of liberal democracy, our legal systems likewise transformed. Thus as homosexuality became widely accepted as a by-product of Modernist ideology, it gradually became legalised across the UK, Australia and parts of the US in the 2010s. Should we all devolve into agreeing about the moral validity of murder, murder will become legal. Should we draw consensus about the goodness of stealing, stealing will become legal. Should we agree that speed limits are useless, speed limits will disappear. This is democracy's strength. Yet this is also democracy's weakness.

The contemporary West's moral and ethical systems have been corrupted by unbridled, neoliberal Capitalism. In response to the Communist states of Eastern Europe that incapacitated any resemblance of individual recognition, the West responded with an ideology of its own. Neoliberalism thus became a mutation of classical liberalism where the actions of citizens and policies of states could be justified by an underlying motive of profit-seeking and meritocracy. Thus, Reagan and Thatcher transformed the US and UK respectively in the 1980s with mass deregulation, privatisation. Much of the work of Modern liberalism in the early 20th century through The New Deal were undone. Neoliberal governments resorted to a laid-back, laissez faire role in the economy but whilst laid-back classical liberal governments still provided a safety net for all individuals, neoliberal governments did no such thing. Instead, attention was focussed not on providing a safety net for those close to falling off the proverbial socioeconomic ladder, but rather for building crowns and palaces for those on the top rung. Neoliberal economists like Freidman in the 1970s questioned the very role of taxation and redistribution of income and instead posited that the Wealthy should indeed be taxed less to reward their inherent 'goodness' in reaching the top. Whilst many in contemporary capitalist societies are capable of reaching the top

income brackets through genuine work ethic and commitment, many yet simply benefit from seeming flaws of the system itself. Thus, former US president Trump accumulates mass wealth not through 'meritocracy' in the way that Freidman may have favoured, but rather through convenient inheritance from his father and consequential serendipity. Ultimately however, neoliberalism has cor-

rupted our ethical and moral compasses in the way that we turn a blind eye to acts of crime. We still the burglar who steals a loaf of bread but are much less reluctant to question the business tycoon that takes advantage of tax loopholes. Billionaires, like Jeff Bezos, across the West get away with this indirect form of ‘stealing’ purely because we do not deem it to be a crime per se. Thus, as is an inherent feature of democracy, our wishes become our state’s command. And tax loopholes are perfectly legal. In this way, it appears that we accommodate and often encourage behaviour that so strikingly contrasts traditional Western morals.

That capitalism has progressed Western civilisation is unquestionable, even for the most left- leaning market sceptics. Yet what remains a concern is to what degree we, as citizens of the West, permit capitalism to protrude into wider elements of liberal democracy. Private corporations like social media companies control and regulate our speech and political campaigns are often launched through private donors. Left, right, up and down. Capitalism Is everywhere. Naturally then, it’s influence is taking a hold of our ethical and moral systems which in turn have affected the legal system in which we live. A unanimous agreement about laws and justice is not required, however. So long as we can acknowledge the growing presence of neoliberal capitalism in all facets of Western life, a recognition of tenets of Western liberalism will naturally emerge. The ethical foundations of the West are today squelched into the trenches by the boot of unbridled capitalism.

Technology

Telescreens or iPhones?

We often think of phones and wider technology as functional ‘toys’ which expand our living standards. Yet as smartphones and social media specifically become more integrated into the daily lives of Western citizens, their controlling nature begins to reveal itself. Where the Telescreen acted as a frightful symbol of invasive technology for Orwell in the mid 20th century, the influence of social media is becoming similarly ubiquitous. Significantly, social media has not just provided us with an opportunity to expand our social reach, it’s changed the rules of socialisation itself. We now have an unprecedented ability to arrange and determine who we socialise with. In losing this spontaneity in socially encountering the unexpected, we speak and listen to only who we want. This can shelter an individual’s social experience, catalysing the creation of echo chambers and political polarisation.

By straying from the natural spontaneity of traditional communication, social media constricts how we interact with other individuals. The ability to select who you follow and who follows you is an inherent trademark feature of most social media platforms. Drawing on concerns of privacy, this kind of feature is usually met with approval from users and has been used by many to arrange their social media profiles accordingly. Yet in a time where social media is beginning to supplant real-life, tangible human interaction (mostly by choice by seldom out of requirement like in the COVID-19 pandemic), this feature is concerning. A natural feature of tangible social communication that individuals have engaged in for hundreds of years has been the element of spontaneity or surprise. We may not ac-

tively be seeking out individuals we disagree with or like, but spontaneously stumbling across a wider range of individuals can enlighten us. Our expansion of knowledge and understanding of the world is contingent on sensation and experience, which was also asserted in the works of Aristotle. Yet on social media, this ability is all but removed due to the narrowness of an individual's audience they want to interact with. This stifles our ability to reflect, stifles our ability to grow and stifles our ability to expand our own ideas. We simply entertain, and let ourselves be entertained by a select, curated group of individuals that we like. The natural spontaneity of tangible interaction should not be overlooked if we share in the fundamental Aristotelian pursuit of knowledge that has characterised the West for centuries. Sheltering our communication in social media echo chambers has created significant polarisation in the West. Throughout history in the West, political progress across a range of issues has been achieved through complex debate between those on opposing sides of the political spectrum. For example, debate between traditional Catholics and Lutheran protestants catalysed change in the Catholic Church. It was only in the face of challenge from protestants did the Catholic Church remove its corrupt indulgences which pressured adherents into 'paying' for their entry to heaven. On a micro level, individuals in the West exercise their imbued right of free speech by conversing with others about pressing social issues. This process either helps individuals understand why they may be misinformed on an issue or it could help approach the nominated issue from an alternative perspective. Yet due to the selective nature of our social media echo chambers, individuals are not exposed to those offering challenging views and perspectives. We tend to follow and be followed by those who share a similar worldview. This thus creates a feedback loop which removes the opportunity for refinement or reconsideration of our positions and instead pushes our worldviews more and more extreme. Thus, in the contemporary West, the mainstream political 'left' and 'right' on social media are manifested in their most extreme forms.

Additionally, it appears to me that through this polarisation to the extreme ends of the political spectrum has given rise to more radical leaders receiving mainstream support. Thus Jeremy Corbyn, a lifetime socialist who represents the very antithesis to traditional England, becomes the UK leader of the opposition in

2018. And Donald Trump becomes the leader of the free world. Unsurprisingly then, the support for these leaders was largely cultivated by rampant social media campaigning on platforms like Twitter and Facebook. Our cultivated selection of those we interact with on social media has therefore stifled natural debate and refined discussion and catalysed an extreme political polarisation in the West. For years, technology has been perceived as our real-life Lego building blocks in Western civilisation. Policies and political rhetoric have often been targeted toward facilitating exponential growth and innovation to fuel further advancement. Largely, we need not sit here and debate the utility of technology and social media. What we should be able to do however is recognise its growing presence and influence on our daily lives in the West. Social media reformed how we communicate and in what capacity we may tolerate and indulge in opposing views. If we can acknowledge this role of social media in the evolution of how we interact in the 21st century, then we should at least debate and discuss how to manage it. Yet therein lies its contradiction as it appears that social media communication has reduced our ability to engage in important discussion. Technology enthusiasts flock to ‘follow’ other enthusiasts. Social media sceptics ‘follow’ other sceptics. And thus, we pull apart. Like two chasms diverging in an earthquake, we grow further and further apart.

Justice

To look beyond our shores, or to look within?

This remains a challenge for many individuals in the contemporary Western world who are torn between a fragmented love for their country and a globalist calling for inclusivity. Globalisation has indeed brought us from all over the world closer than ever before, but as liberal nations are quickly realising - this is unsustainable. Taking off the neoliberal tainted glasses that Western citizens are encouraged to wear, many individuals are grappling with cultural tensions and economic challenges that globalisation brings. An erosion of national identity and stifling of local industry has given rise to a more recent opposition to globalisation. One of national love and patriotism. Yet this kind of inward-looking patriotism can easily give rise to a collectivist, “us versus them” narrative which brings can bring forth antagonism and distrust of the “outsider”. Yet it seems to me, that if we agree that the classical liberal backbone of our contemporary West explains much of our rampant economic development since the 17th century, we ought to resist this rise of growing nationalist sentiment and embrace global inclusivity.

A populace motivated by an underlying nationalist sentiment directly opposes foundational principles of liberal democracy. Growing out of the destructive, corrupt monarchist state in 18th century France, the French Revolution brought about the development of an egalitarian movement called liberalism. Liberalism has since quickly gone on to influence the political and economic structures of the Western world. Yet arguably it’s most prominent feature, individualism, which centred around a universal recognition of the value and role of the individ-

ual instead of the collective, has come under direct threat as a result of rising nationalist sentiment. As Immanuel Kant posited regarding this development of Individual value, “the individual has become an end itself”, whereas it has otherwise been seen as a mere facilitator for collective progress. Thus, societies in the West recognised the innate value of the individual as codified by various constitutions across the Western world. Part of this includes a recognition of the universal rights to freedom and autonomy that should be granted to all individuals, regardless of collective identity or demographic. Yet, in generating a “us versus them” dynamic, nationalist sentiment in the contemporary West is dismantling these foundational elements of our societies. Increased border protection in Australia for example has seen asylum seekers deported to offshore islands which walk a dangerous line between acceptable state behaviour and a breaking of recognised human rights. It seems to me quite probable that if domestic Australians were treated in this manner, public outrage would be deafening. Isolationism and more stringent border control has become synonymous with the nationalist movement as it’s also dominated the policies of politicians that have galvanised patriotic citizens. Priti Patel’s deportation of Eastern Europeans post-Brexit and Trump’s building of the wall on the US-Mexico border. Thus, it seems to me that overly nationalist sentiment of this manner, sits in a stark contrast to foundational liberal values. Liberal democratic principles have played, and should continue to play, a central role in creating a just and fair Western society. For centuries after the French revolution, citizens of the West may have disagreed on taxation policy. They may have disagreed on the extent to which government should play a role in income redistribution. Or they may have disagreed on whether or not we should be fighting in international conflict and war. But one thing that we all seemed to have agreed upon was that liberal democracy was our starting point. It was an *a priori* assumption from all other political debate was carried out. That radicalists on the left and right have abandoned this recognition seems like a likely explanation of the increased polarisation in the contemporary West. Both radicals on the left and right are increasingly

pushing for collective identity to triumph over the individual. Yet it seems to me that remaining faithful to our liberal democratic tradition is the most appro-

priate way to preserve a just and fair society. Individualism has given birth to a remarkable universal recognition of human rights and democracy has built on this to ensure that political power is vested not in an oppressive minority, but rather in the hearts and minds of the populace. Eastern nations that are slowly embracing these liberal ideals, seems to me a clear sign of the growing recognition that liberalism is a potent vehicle for just and fair change. The collapse of the Soviet Union, East Germany and Communist China has seen these nations not double down on hierarchical, collectivist principles. But rather embrace liberal attitudes from the West. And whilst Russia and China in particular are still yet to completely embrace liberalism, it seems to me that the rampant economic and social development in these countries over the past 40 years is at least correlated with their uptake in liberal ideals. It thus seems to me that we in the West are forgetting that what makes our societies relatively just and fair is our emphasis on the foundational role of liberalism in our nations.

To expect all individuals in the West to abandon any kind of patriotic or nationalist sentiment would be naive. Individuals maintain a kind of inherent leaning toward this “us versus them” mentality that has driven the nationalist sentiment. Yet, we need not all entirely agree that nationalist sentiment is definitively harmful. If we can recognise that liberal values that have steered the West into the relatively fortuitous state that it currently is in, then we can agree on at least preserving the foundational aspects of the philosophy. It seems to me that nationalism, in the way that it has protruded into the contemporary political conversation, deviates away from many of these foundational liberal principles. Thus, as citizens in the West that will naturally feel this nationalist sentiment to some extent, we should be aware of the conflict between these feelings and the core tenets of our Western world.

Politics

Manipulation and politicians.

For an individual within today's cultural environment, such terms are considered synonymous. Whether from the left or right, politicians are viewed with an animosity and distaste. It seems clear to me that this kind of perception sits in direct contrast to the way in which we should view our political leaders - with pride and inspiration. Yet in our Modern Western societies, the mutation of our liberal tradition into an ideology of Neoliberalism has given birth to a political system of vote-buying and manipulation. This counters the very nature of the politics and democracy which emerged out of classical liberalism, where politics once acted as a noble domain to protect and uphold our individual and communal wants. Where once A and B worked together to protect our own and collective interests, democracy has today morphed into a manipulative game of superiority between citizens and politicians.

The recent emergence of Neoliberalism as a mutation of Western tradition has plagued the political realm with commodification and vote-buying. Amidst the rising threat of Eastern European and Asian communism, the West clung dearly to its liberal and capitalist roots and its democracies began to morph into commodified states throughout the 20th century. And thus began the raging ideology of neoliberalism, which claims to address and resolve all of Western societies concerns, economic or not, through the power of the free market and rapid deregulation. Such singular focus on marketisation has naturally bled beyond the economic domain and found itself front and centre in the political sphere. Significantly however, the commodified society we find ourselves in today is a distorted zero-

sum game; for each winner lies hundreds of losers. For each multinational corporation which expands its presence in a new market, comes hundreds of small businesses that must shut down as they are incapable of competing. Thus, politics today becomes a game of standing in the winner's circle, and necessarily pushing others into the loser's circle. Like in the US election of 2016 - Trump harnessed not harmonious politics of unity and harmony but rather this very divisive form of politics to gain support. The revitalisation of the US manufacturing sector and trade war with China became such a potent form of political campaigning because of how it cultivated an image of disenfranchised Americans returning to that proverbial winner's circle of capitalism. These same disenfranchised Americans who were thrown out and left to anguish in the loser's circle as a result of the mass marketisation and rapid globalisation of the 1980s which left them incapable of competing against foreign nations. Hence, the commodification of society that has arisen out of Neoliberalism has divided society on economic terms and consequently led politics becoming a game of winners and losers rather than one where entities can cooperate.

Returning to Western societies' roots of classical liberalism would clearly contravene this deterioration of democracy and lead us toward a harmonious political future. Where classical liberalism once placed the individual at the heart of politics, today's Western society places the market at the heart. Classical liberalism posits a philosophy where human rights and compassion arises naturally as we hold the individual in the highest regard. It seems to me, through this lens of where liberalism once began, politicians should be perceived as those in society whom we wish to be our children's role models and those who embody the noble and compassionate values we aspire toward. It seems to me then that a politician like Trump, with a history of tax evasion and sexual assault, would lie as a direct contradiction to this conception of an ideal political candidate. To address our political system's tendency toward manipulation, we must look toward a framework which offers a suitable replacement. A

system which beckons our citizens to vote with their minds rather than wallets is one that would allow us to be proud of our politicians, rather than cast them as corporate criminals. To be a politician means to stand and protect the interests of

an entire populace. Yet in the current political sphere, with rampant tendency of polarised citizens to vote single-mindedly with their wallets rather than minds, our politicians are more synonymous with devious corporates rather than role models. The commodification and marketisation of our Western societies that has risen with the recent wave of Neoliberalism has pushed our democracies to be more divisive than cooperative. Thus, as the emerging generation that is plagued by such hostile and manipulative politics, we must remember politics should be the art of 'A and B both enter the winner's circle together'.

Rich & Poor

Buy or be bought. Control or be controlled.

The fixation on capitalistic accumulation and wealth generation in contemporary Western society has led to this divisive mentality. Social signalling in the West has taught us that the primary objective of any individual should be to craft a life that optimises the pursuit for wealth. Despite resting on its foundational principles of liberalism and individualism, Western society's economic focus become more neoliberal and capitalist in nature. In fact, in this increasingly consumerist Western society, it seems to me that this relentless pursuit of wealth and capital governs our behaviour to an extent that ironically erodes our liberty and individuality.

Due to the commodification of our daily lives that arises out of neoliberalism, the lives of citizens in the contemporary West are effectively governed by the underlying pursuit of wealth. Emerging in response to the communist and authoritarian states that dominated Eastern Europe and Asia in the mid 20th century, the West responded with a new form of liberalism. Neoliberalism. Where once classical liberalism inspired the West through the confidence and faith individuals placed in its institutions, 20th century Neoliberalism bred on a growing distrust of government amid fears of manipulation and propaganda after World War 2. Thus, through the growth of neoliberalism, rapid economic growth and capital accumulation replaced the individual as the most sacred centrepiece of Western society. It's this ideology which drove Reagan's US and Thatcher's UK to implement widespread policies to deregulate markets and drive the significance of consumerism in supporting the flailing economies. Yet what these revolutionary

Western governments failed to recognise was the way in which an obsession with economic growth and consumerism would affect the citizens they governed. These policies have forced individuals to prioritise ‘winning’ this distorted zero sum game of wealth in contemporary Western economies. One winner creates hundreds of losers. The joys of one business result in the plight of thousands of employees. It thus seems to me that as a result of this undercurrent of meritocracy and wealth accumulation, the choices made by citizens in the West today are inevitably influenced and controlled by this underlying desire for wealth. This is clearly evident in the tertiary education choices of young individuals in the West. Where fields such as the arts were once reverently upheld as opportunities to develop an appreciation for the culture that makes up Western society, today’s youth tend to select degrees purely based on its capacity to generate wealth later in life. Hence, faculties such as Business, Law and Engineering attract the best high school graduates due to the promise of later wealth. Further, later in life - job selection is primarily determined by the salary an individual would be paid. Low salary growth is cited as the leading cause of not only employee dissatisfaction but also for employees leaving one employer for another. It thus seems to me that in the contemporary West that is heavily influenced by neoliberalism, daily choices are being governed and controlled by an underlying pursuit of wealth.

Yet to remain true to its liberal roots that have allowed Western society to prosper for the past millennia, we must moderate the extent to which this desire for wealth accumulation governs our lives. At its core, liberalism prioritises the freedom and value of the individual above all else. Recognising value that emerges beyond just wealth accumulation is important in encouraging individuals in the West to grow and prosper as human beings rather than economic tools. It is here where it seems to me the West should humble itself and look at what Eastern traditions have done to facilitate a spiritually meaningful life. In Indian tradition, practices such as yoga and meditation have permanently been mainstays of a

healthy daily routine. These practices serve as a detox from the otherwise economic world that surrounds even the Indian culture in 2022 as it has also attempted to embrace Western ideals of capitalism. Yet in turn, despite this, these individuals retain a connection to their spiritual selves that enables personal

growth, reflection, and maturity beyond just the domain of economics, wealth, and income. Eastern traditions like Buddhism, Hinduism and Taoism all share a similarity of placing the individual's spiritual health as the most reverent element of Being. The West prioritises the individual, but now, due to neoliberalism, it prioritises the economic value that an individual may bring and judges these individuals based on their earning capacity. The West should consider reconnecting with its own spiritual roots in Judea-Christian values to therefore supplant the economic individual with the content individual.

The West once represented the best of humanity. It's unprecedented insistence on the sacred value of liberty and the individual contrasted deeply with more crude and barbaric societies before it. Yet in the 21st century, in an attempt to curb the rise of communist ideologies, this liberalism has been supplanted by neoliberalism, an ideology itself. In turn, citizens in the contemporary West see the only metric measuring their value as their earning capacity and capability to contribute to the economic machine. Rather, as citizens in the contemporary West that recognise the overwhelming influence that neoliberalism is having, we should aspire to grow beyond such shallow definitions of 'personal value'. We can look to the East and observe how these traditions continue to place spiritual, internal health as the ultimate pursuit - not wealth creation. If not, the economic machine of the West will continue to grow. Continue to destroy. Continue to control.

Consumerism #2

Human beings, not tools.

Western society, at least since the Enlightenment, has upheld the individual and liberalism as the very heart of its civilisation. As a necessary consequence of this, citizenship has been a crucial element of our involvement in the democratic process. With our ability to vote and influence political leadership, we as individuals, become citizens rather than pedestrians. Yet, through a recent emergence of mass marketisation and commodification in the West, citizens are being replaced by consumers. Where once we saw no difference between an individual who could vote and one who contributed to the economy, today's neoliberal economic structures posit that an individual's primary role is to earn and consume. Hence, as individuals are increasingly abandoning their responsibility as active participants in the democratic process, the liberal democratic structure that Western nations are predicated on is collapsing.

A functioning Western liberal democracy requires individuals to actively participate in the political process. In the way that it was borne out of the Renaissance, classical liberalism placed a central focus on the individual and the inherent rights and responsibilities that came with it. Previous societies in the West that were entirely governed by tyrannic monarchies and dynasties once shunned the rights of the individual. Yet with the recognition of the 'inalienable rights of the individual', as codified in the constitution of USA, came a recognition that individuals have a role to play in the political process. For such rights to be upheld, our involvement in voting and retaining political leaders who enshrine these values should ultimately lie in our hands. It seems to me that, on an individ-

ual level, playing the 'citizen's role' and contributing to the voting of elections is deeply embedded in our Western societies' prioritisation of the individual. Further, a functioning democracy requires politicians to be kept accountable by citizens who are actively participating in the political process. When we look to our history's darkest corners, such as Hitler's Nazi regime in Germany, it was the very incapability for citizens to participate in the political process which enabled such a government to commit the atrocities of genocide. Should a citizen have spoken up and attempted to becoming critically involved in the political realm, death, oppression, and suppression awaited them. Instead, it's the capability for citizens, to assess their political leaders, criticise and moreover become involved in the democratic process, which provides a clear incentive for such leaders to 'bend to the will' of the individual. Hence, if we assume that our Western nations are built on the almost sacred value we place on the individual, then people must be able to actively participate in the political process. The power should lie with the individual.

Yet, the marketisation and commodification of our daily lives has distracted our individuals to becoming consumers instead of citizens. In response to the raging Communist regimes of the East in the 20th century, Western economies became obsessed with capitalism and marketisation and thus gave birth to their own ideology, Neoliberalism. As a result, the tunnel vision focus on free markets and their capacity to seemingly resolve all issues; political, social, and economic overcame the precious values that emerged from classical liberalism. In turn, as individuals in the West, we have forsaken our obligations to play the role of critical citizen and instead we masquerade as robotic, economic consumers. It seems to me that as individuals in the West, we place much more significance over personal finance issues such as tax cuts and income growth over deeply political and social issues that concern the community. Hence, instead of acting as participatory citizens that vote with their minds and hearts, we vote with our wallets. Thus, it seems to me, that the attraction for populist and elite

leaders like Donald Trump and Boris Johnson comes not from a desire to elect leaders to embody attitudes we appreciate or act as role models. The attraction comes from their desire to implement economic policies which line our pockets.

Thus, in his campaigning, Trump focused not on his own moral character as the ‘leader of the free world’, but rather in his capacity to generate more income for the average American through tax cuts and a revitalisation of the manufacturing industry. To be a ‘citizen’ in our democracies means to be active in vocalising our concerns and support for deeply political and social issues as well as economic ones. Yet it seems like in today’s Modern West, flashy economic policies captivate us and distract us from more pressing issues. Tax cuts line our pockets, but the increased production that comes from it enables mass production which damages our environment. Where once TV killed the radio star, consumerism looks set to kill citizenship. Ultimately, the role of a citizen is more than a simple one. It’s something that embodies the spirit of Western democracy. It’s a participatory role that represents our liberal values of freedom and equality whilst also ensuring that governments are kept accountable and bend to the will of the voter base they seek to serve. Yet it seems to me that the way in which we have pivoted as a society, toward a much stronger economic focus, has distorted this role for citizenship. Our value as individuals comes not from our ability to buy and earn, but rather our ability to become involved politically. If we recognise the role for freedom and equality in our Western traditions, then we must also recognise the invaluable role that citizens play. To vote and elect. That is our truest calling as citizens of the West.

Welfare

Tax cuts for me, tax cuts for you, tax cuts for us all.

Political propaganda in the West will often direct our support for such policies through the lens of each voter being able to keep a greater share of their income. Yet, naturally, these policy announcements fail to address the flip side, the reduction in government revenue and thus a miniaturisation of the presence of the state. In our Modern Western nations, the traditional conception of the individual being at the heart of our political and economic realms has been corrupted and overthrown by a rise in neoliberal capitalism. This pervasive ideology has led to mass marketisation, and a tunnel vision focus on meritocracy which entrenches inequality. It seems therefore that, distracted by our desire for wealth creation and marketisation, Western governments have abandoned their welfare role which ironically places the collective pursuit for wealth above those individuals who require a 'safety net'.

Due the commodification of our daily lives that arises out of neoliberalism, Western governments increasingly play a passive role in welfare. In response to the growth of Eastern communist states in the early 20th century, the Western world reemphasised the role of the market and capitalism, thus giving birth to their own ideology, Neoliberalism. It's this ideology which guided 20th century regimes such as Reagan's USA and Thatcher's UK toward mass deregulation and marketisation. What arose was undoubtedly an increase in employment, rapid rise in productivity and income growth. Yet what was left behind was a government who cared compassionately for all citizens, not just those who emerged victorious from the capitalist game. Neoliberalism necessarily gave birth to meritocracy and thus

emerged a divisive rhetoric of ‘you get what you work for’. It seems to me that meritocracy gives rise to a sort of distorted zero-sum game, where one winner creates hundreds of losers. Hence, where meritocracy provides a clear pathway for the hyper-productive entrepreneur who accumulates millions in wealth, it also creates the downfall for hundreds of smaller businesses who collapse due to an incapability to compete. Therefore, it seems to me that here lies our particular domain for debate; whether our governments should be responsible for a welfare state which cares for and provides the necessary ‘safety net’ for the hundreds of employees which suffer from this meritocracy. Hence, the rising marketisation and consequent meritocracy has plagued our economy with inevitable inequality which Western governments do not address completely.

To remain true to the principle of liberty which has driven all of Western society for the past millennium, governments must recognise their welfare role. In Western nations, principles of liberty and the individual once sat at the heart of our democratic process and economy. Everything that came out of the West over the past millennium can effectively be traced back to the conception of the individual. With this, as codified in the USA constitution, is a recognition that all individuals are entitled to inalienable human rights and equality. Yet to accentuate the free market and encourage spurious levels of innovation and growth, our Western governments today play an increasingly diminished welfare role. Naturally, this has given birth to raging inequality in the West, but it seems to me that economic inequality of this nature does not need to be a feature of capitalism. Instead, if we assume that capitalism also arose out of principles of liberty and the focus of the individual, then governments have a political and economic role to play. To align with liberalism as it first bore out of the enlightenment, governments have the responsibility to create a welfare state to the extent that it ensures an equal opportunity for all to engage in the capitalist game. The problem, as it seems to me, is that those who emerge from lower socio-economic households that require

the ‘safety net’ initially, are left languishing at the bottom rungs of the capitalist ladder. True liberalism recognises the importance of the welfare state in creating equal opportunity for all individuals, not just the wealthy ones.

That everyone in society benefits from a welfare state, feels like an oversimplification of the issue. Naturally, the economic elite would much rather cling to their millions in cash rather than take part of the redistributive role of welfare. Yet, should we assume that as a Western community we maintain the almost sacred importance on the individual, then the presence of welfare in our economy emerges as self-evident. Tax cuts are great, but a Western society where we all are afforded the opportunities to succeed, would be even greater.

Cancel Culture

Congress shall not abridge free speech.

For centuries, the West has prided itself on liberal values—individuality, freedom of speech, and open discourse. Western societies have historically prided themselves on their commitment to free expression and the open exchange of ideas, viewing these principles as essential to democracy. However, the rise of digital outrage and mass social exclusion has transformed public discourse, prioritising immediate moral retribution over constructive debate. While accountability remains a crucial aspect of justice, cancel culture often bypasses legal and ethical considerations, leading to an environment where ideological purity takes precedence over dialogue and critical thinking. This shift fundamentally challenges the philosophical and political foundations of Western liberalism. Cancel culture in the West, while initially rooted in social accountability, has evolved into a mechanism of ideological coercion that undermines the liberal principles of free speech and due process.

The ability to challenge ideas, express dissent, and engage in rational debate is foundational to the development of knowledge and democracy. Classical liberalism, as articulated by Enlightenment thinkers such as John Stuart Mill, views free speech as a mechanism to refine truth through the contestation of ideas. In *On Liberty*, Mill argues that even incorrect opinions contribute to intellectual progress by allowing for their refutation, reinforcing the strength of valid arguments. Similarly, Jürgen Habermas' concept of communicative rationality emphasises that democratic legitimacy emerges from unrestricted dialogue where all perspectives are considered. These principles have long served as the backbone of

Western societies, ensuring that no single ideology monopolises discourse. However, the rise of digital platforms has altered the dynamics of public discussion, fostering environments where the risk of reputational destruction dissuades individuals from engaging in controversial or critical conversations. As a result, the pluralism that once defined liberal societies is being eroded in favour of ideological homogeneity enforced by mass social pressure.

As such, cancel culture, in the contemporary West, operates as a mechanism of public shaming that enforces ideological conformity through social and economic penalties. Initially intended to hold individuals and institutions accountable for discriminatory behaviour, it has since evolved into an extrajudicial process where social media outrage serves as judge, jury, and executioner. Whilst it's inarguable that it has often been a force for good in prosecuting otherwise unreachable individuals such as Harvey Weinstein, cancel culture reaches a tipping point. The pendulum can swing too far. Where we are at with cancel culture echoes French sociologist Emile Durkheim's theory of collective consciousness explains how shared moral beliefs can unify societies, but also warns of their capacity to enforce excessive conformity at the expense of individual autonomy. In the current digital age, corporations and institutions, driven by reputational and financial concerns, frequently capitulate to public pressure by disassociating from individuals who become targets of cancel culture, regardless of the validity of the accusations against them. This preemptive action reinforces a culture of fear where dissent is not engaged with or debated but punished outright. Consequently, rather than encouraging progress through discussion and understanding, cancel culture creates an

exclusionary system where deviation from dominant narratives is met with immediate and severe consequences, undermining the principles of justice and due process.

Ultimately, cancel culture represents a fundamental contradiction within Western liberal democracies. While it emerged as a form of social accountability, it now operates as a punitive mechanism that contradicts the very principles of free expression and open discourse that underpin democratic society. True progress is

not achieved through suppression but through the engagement and contestation of ideas, allowing societies to refine their moral and intellectual frameworks. If the West is to preserve its foundational commitment to individual freedom, it must resist the impulse to sacrifice open dialogue in favour of ideological conformity. Protecting the principles of free speech and due process ensures that justice is pursued without eroding the core values that define democratic governance.

Disillusionment

“We choose you”

This is the kind of rhetoric we, as citizens of the modern Western world hear daily. A type of rhetoric that leads us to believe that our governments are with us. Fighting for us. For us. The reality is that in the contemporary West, governments are neglecting their once presumed default role of protection and democratic fighting for our rights. Instead, our democratic systems are crumbled, plagued by the influence of neoliberal politics emerging from the populist right that has eroded the capacity for public institutions to protect and preserve the liberal rights of the people.

The modern West's public institutions have been infested by self-interested politicians who no longer uphold liberal, democratic values. This change in Western politics markedly accelerated in the mid 20th century when developed Western economies embraced Neoliberalism - an economic ideology obsessed with the pursuit of free markets, economic growth, and globalisation. In turn, our philosophy toward the role of government has completely morphed. Where during the World Wars we relied on and trusted our Western governments to support citizens through welfare, today we perceive the smallest government as the most efficient. This is because of the neoliberal assumption that a small government that taxes less and redistributes less will, through trickle-down economics, lead to an overall rise in welfare as business grows and flourishes. Company tax rates across all modern Western economies are lower than they were in World War 2 for this very reason, to spuriously encourage corporate growth at the cost of redistribution. But our government systems overlook how this hyper-productivity perspective

ignores the needs of the many who rely on the welfare state to sustain a workable standard of living. Whilst Western democracies do house the largest and most successful corporations of our generation, we also house some of the largest inequality in the world. Within this system therefore, society rewards political candidates who can promise wealth and prosperity. No coincidence then that the American population elected multi-billionaire Donald Trump to presidency in 2016. Evidently, over recent times our political time has not been conducive to traditionally liberal and democratic values.

Instead, today, such neoliberal tendencies have ultimately corrupted our entire democratic landscape and continue to lead us down a pathway of misgovernance and corruption. It is no coincidence that the recent emergence of populism across the West has quickly followed this rise of neoliberalism. When our government institutions design economic policy with the underlying objective of only pursuing growth and hyper-productivity, they naturally give rise to voter bases who are prone to succumbing to manipulative politicians who promise monetary gain. And in turn, politicians are motivated not by those traditional aspirations of benevolent leadership but rather by the thirst to be powerful and in turn control the economic and financial state of their society. What results is an overall destabilisation of democracy since values of economic gain overshadow perhaps more benevolent values of honesty and truth. The insurrection on the capital in 2021 demonstrated how the American far-right voter base's concern over the foreign infiltration of the USA economy and losing neoliberal economic policy under Trump outweighed their concern for quite literally attempting to overthrow the metonymy of Western democracy in the Capitol.

The recent emergence of neoliberalism has led to a sudden shift in governments across the Modern Western world embracing a much smaller role and relinquishing their invaluable responsibility to care for citizens across the economy. Where once our governments "held the sword" to lead and inspire our democratic rights, the responsibility now falls on the shoulders. As a result of this, our democratic institutions are at risk of a populist overthrow as the obsession of economic values blinds us. So now we "swing" our "swords" to defend ourselves

from the chaotic world surrounding us. All alone, we swing. We fight. And it's this isolation and fight that our politicians thrive off.

Part Two: Task B

Religion

For so long, religion was about palaces of jewels, diamonds, and statues.

The mandir, Hindu temple, that we frequented every few weeks was a sight to see. It's rich red, bountiful blue and gorgeous gold surrounded me. Statues of Ganesh, Ram and Krishna filled the wide-open space with rugged brown mats across the hall for adherents to kneel down onto and pray. More inspiring, there was a degree of social connection I felt with everyone there. Out in the streets of north-west Sydney, I was, usually, a racial minority. So, to be in a setting like this where I felt like I belonged was different. Yet, however, everytime I asked my dad why he kept referring to our only Hindu neighbour as a "schedule" his response felt dismissive. I don't think dad is a bad person, he has been my hero. But it always bugged me how his faithfulness to Hinduism guided many of his admirable qualities, but also some of his more divisive views steeped in a historical adherence to Hindu scripture. Was there no grey to religion I wondered? Just black and white it seemed.

As I look back at my experience with Hinduism as a young child, I'm reminded of how whilst religion can provide a degree of social cohesion, dogmatically abiding by it can lead to a divisive and narrow-minded perspective. The religious experience, beyond just Hinduism, invites a degree of communal cohesion that I don't think many other things can do. Perhaps it has something to do with the idea, as espoused especially clearly in the Judeo-Christian tradition, that all individuals are made in the "image and likeness" of God. This necessarily encourages a degree of civility, common respect and cohesion that has taken deep roots in the

liberal tradition of the West since the French Revolution. Emerging from this comes the creation of clear ethical systems, which has historically acted as the bedrock for legal and justice systems across the world. It's this degree of recognising what is "above us" that humbles us. Indeed, when the Soviet Union dispelled the idea of Christian religion and instead placed the collectivist goal of communism at the heart of Russian society, chaos and rampant human rights abuse transpired. This was, of course, reminiscent of Nietzsche's chilling warning of the ramifications of chaotic secularism. "God is dead", he announced. Not a triumphant declaration, but more of a eulogy. Yet religion, as it's steeped in tradition, often finds it difficult to adapt to the evolving social structures we live through. This is, it seems to me, why the conservative right in the contemporary West seems to almost always be filled with religious adherents. To that extent it seems to me that religion taken with a grain of salt allows us to reap its spiritual benefits whilst being cognisant of its limitations. Dogmatically following scripture and traditional teachings from a different millennium is of course going to come into conflict with a contemporary society that has so substantially evolved since. Following religion in this way creates a narrow-mindedness and closed off approach that inhibits an individual's capacity to learn, grow and adapt. Which, it must be said, also rings true for hyper-secularists and atheists who are often dogmatically obsessed with scientific rationality, living in a sort of Cartesian utopia of the logical mind. Yet as our society stretches to fit in conceptions of secularism whilst remaining faithful to the religious roots of our ethical systems, questions arise. Dogmatism closes us off.

To that extent, with the growing secularism of contemporary Western developed societies, dogmatism has spread across into the political realm too. In that way, to many, Republicanism or being a Democrat is a religion in of itself. Vox news is the new Bible. Donald Trump is the new Jesus. And this kind of reverent passion is not foreign to those on the left either. Idealistic leaders like Emmanuel Macron in France are looked upon almost as saviours, in the same way we once saw Christ. To that extent political bases are prone to dogmatically loving their political leaders in the same way religious adherents are at times prone to dogmatically abiding by religion. The affiliation and idea of being a "Republican" seems

to today, trump what it actually means to be a Republican. Pun intended. To that extent, the identification of being from a political party trumps the actual values of said party. Republicans, for decades, especially after the relatively prosperous presidency of Ronald Reagan in the 1980s, were characterised by a passionate love for free trade. Yet when the tables turned and incoming Republican leader Donald Trump leveraged a cultural war with China, this value was quickly forgotten. Today, Republicans can largely be identified as being protectionist junkies. Another tariff, another hit. What's missing from the political realm is the ability for proponents of either side to remember that we share common values which transcend partisan politics. Once upon a time in the West, this common value was liberalism and the impassioned love for individuality that stemmed from it. Yet as the right becomes more patriotically populist and the left becomes more collectivist, this shared space is lost. That common ground collapses. The earthquake hits us all. And its tremors shake the ground under us. It leaves us in free fall, without common ground. And so, in response, we cling even more strongly and blindly to our beloved political parties.

Religion has, seemingly, been a part of human civilisation since the start of history. Beyond Judeo-Christianity, it's emerged as a fundamental part of ancient civilisations including the Indigenous spirituality. And it has of course been a crucial source of meaning, identity and belonging for individuals throughout this time. It's provided a source of social cohesion and commonality that has ensured the success of justice and legal systems since. Yet as time progresses, so should our values. So should our attitudes. But religion is not as dynamic as we'd like to think. It's inherent connection to scripture keeps it static and relatively stuck in the past. Islamic Jurisprudence and Catholic Councils in recent history have sought to keep the religions in modern check but this evidently has not been enough. Religion in the contemporary world should be taken, therefore, with a pinch of salt. Its importance can be recognised but abiding rigidly and dogmatically poses issues. The caste system of Hinduism is, of course, an outdated religious precept. It predates Judaism or Christianity itself. Indeed, the inherent inequality of the 4-tiered caste system strikes a devastating contradiction to India's own modern identity as a democratic nation. With its rich culture, tantalising

palaces and moving rituals, Hinduism has always captivated me. But dogmatically following it would leave me casting aside respect for my neighbour. And as Jesus once said. “Love thy neighbour, as I have loved you”.

Cynicism

“Son, tell me. How do you feel? How is the pain?”

It was weird hearing that from my dad. For the last few years, my dad and I have had a somewhat fractured relationship. His traditional conceptions of how I should “be” as a young adult mixed in with tense disagreements about my living situation at home have led to a fairly muted relationship over the past few years. Most prominently, as he ventured out to start a new business and I lent him a few thousand dollars of my own savings, I never got it back. “Business loss” he said. So easily. It became hard for me to forgive that. Perhaps it’s because as a young adult I’m blinded by the consumerist world around me and tie a bit too much importance to that money. But deeply I felt it as a betrayal of my trust. Nonetheless, a deeply fractured relationship. And so, when I fell ill with a flare-up for an autoimmune condition of mine, his compassionate approach felt... foreign. It wasn’t right. I was hesitant to embrace his help. Yet as I look back, perhaps I forfeited an easy way to mend our relationship. It was, after all, within my grasp.

It seems to me that individuals who are increasingly cynical to those who have previously wronged them tend to limit their capacity for forgiveness and growth. It is, it must be said, a fairly natural response to distrust someone that has wronged us. It is, evolutionarily speaking, a critical component of our psyche, so as to learn from past betrayals and conflict and ensure we sustain survival. To that extent however it appears to me likely that this kind of evolutionary instinct is particularly limiting in a 21st contemporary West that is fairly civilised. Sure, a natural response to a bad experience. But wherein do we account for the learning and reformation that can emerge from such difficult interactions. To be cynical is

to be pessimistic. It's a kind of worldview which assumes the worst in humanity and honestly, fair enough. Slavery, colonialism, and greed. Characteristics that embodied even the most "liberal" and "free" civilisations of the West. We can't knock the instinctive human desire to act with a level of self-interest and lack of integrity. Yet whilst this is the easy choice, it isn't especially the smartest. It seems to me that relationships, especially with close family and friends, requires a degree of openness to forgiveness to stand a chance of progressing. Conflict, after all, is inevitable. Betrayal too, is only an argument away. Yet if we give up on each other and simply assume the worst, wherein can we engage in meaningful reconciliation? Indeed 18th century philosopher Jean Jacques Rousseau spoke widely in his treatise *Emile* on the inherent goodness of "man". Indeed, whilst these sentiments are traditionally upheld by the Christian faith too - it seems to me to be a more productive way to view the world. On that, the horrors of humanity's past seem to haunt us like a Dickensian Christmas Past. It's the recognition of these horrors that we establish a more cynical view of our peers, family, and friends. My girlfriend of 3 years and I have been in so many arguments, I've lost count. I promise, they weren't all my fault. Even still however, it's an underlying trust and willingness to believe the other person that has allowed us to resolve issues everytime. The second either of us were to fall suspicious or cynical, would spell the end to our relationship. Cynicism kills. Trust and forgiveness flourish.

Even taking this idea to the political realm of the contemporary West, it seems me that relentless cynicism of the "other" is what is fuelling an aggressive polarisation of both sides

of politics. In contemporary US for example, both the Republican party on the right and Democratic party on the left have strayed far out to the extremes of the political spectrum. Reagan would cringe at the thought of President Trump. And Eisenhower cringes at the thought of President Kamala Harris. Yet the more pressing issue on the ground is the degree to which citizens within the US are developing a vitriolic hatred between each other. Where once we shared the foundational principles of liberty, freedom, and individualism, both major parties have strayed away. Far-right populism and far-left collectivism pose a clear threat to these fundamental assumptions of the left. Therefore, where once we may have

disagreed with our neighbours on tax policy or concessions, we shared a recognition of liberalism. It was this one shared value that ensured some degree of civility in political discourse. Conflict and criticism in the political realm used to be a democratic exercise in “punching up” and governments and political leaders. Today however, we “punch around”. You punch me. I punch you. Liberalism collapses. Cynicism thrives.

To be a cynic is to see the worst in humanity. It is to view another’s actions and behaviour through a hedonistic lens of self-interest and greed rather than from a compassionate place of love and generosity. Truthfully, I feel like this issue has gone to the deepest roots of political discourse today as well, where the left and right seemingly cannot find a common place to share in recognising each other’s value as human beings. We are cynical of each other’s motivations, and this thus catalyses a painfully destructive political polarisation. I remained cynical of my dad’s motivations. Perhaps he’s trying to gain my trust to borrow more money. Perhaps I’ll let him in and he’ll devastate my trust again. Or perhaps he was simply yearning to connect deeply to his ill child. I guess we’ll never know.

Travel

The scent was guttural, and the skies were misty.

As I stepped out of Delhi airport, it seemed all I could hear was the constant blaring of car horns and a mass rush of people around me to the level that I'd only ever seen in movies. Whilst I have an Indian background, this was my first time in the country after 11 years in Australia. Indeed, throughout my youth I held tightly onto my Australian identity, feeling afraid to embrace the Indian side of my heritage. "I'm Australian, not Indian" I'd defiantly tell my dad when the cricket was on. They all supported India. I supported Australia. Yet it was that first experience in India, running through the musty streets of Delhi, feeling like I was just one ant amidst an army of a thousand. Eating at dingy street eateries and more polished restaurants. It started to crystallise in my head. Perhaps I was wrong. Perhaps Dad was right. Perhaps embracing my Indian heritage wasn't just about smelly food, red dots, and cricket. Perhaps there was something more.

As I reminisce in my first trip to India, I'm reminded of how travel is capable of opening our minds up to a more compassionate worldview through shared lived experience. Specifically, travelling into cultures and societies that so starkly differ to the ones we usually inhabit. More often than not, as humans, we stick to our packs and develop a kind of "us versus them" mentality. It's what, to some extent, embellishes our local social harmony and ensures that we have close knit communities to live in. It's this very dynamic that truly galvanises and awakens the animal spirit in sport fans across any sport, for example. Sport fans are willing to die, proverbially, for their teams and in turn, create menacing narratives about

rivals and opposing teams. Love Australian Cricket, hate the Poms. Love the Swans, hate the Giants. Yet what we often see is this “us versus them” dynamic can often reveal itself in more menacing and prejudicial ways. It is, it appears to me, the very dynamic which has fuelled racism, sexism and all the discriminatory “isms” you can think of. Perhaps, however, the reason to which we cannot all link hands and live peacefully comes from the lack of shared experience and that is what generates this “us versus them” dynamic. And so, one may be racist, not due to an inherent evilness within them, but rather due to a lack of lived experience to truly understand and empathise with the other. Whilst racism still exists across the US for example, the reduction of segregation across “white” and “black” boundaries has allowed both cultures to co-exist leading to a greater understanding and empathy. To that extent then, what better way to share in a lived experience of one we may consider “the other” than to travel into their culture. Into their lands. Into their communities. Travel has a unique way of humbling even the most arrogant. When you struggle to even ask for a glass of water at an eatery, you realise the breadth of language and culture you lack. And what you lack, the “other” has in mass. Travel allows us to not just witness other cultures, but rather to live through them. Indeed, 18th century philosophers Soren Kierkegaard and David Hume both agreed on the significance of the “experience” in the way that it shapes an individual’s perspective. As humans, travel is not just a tourist luxury that strokes our desire to go on holidays. Rather, it presents itself as a truly transformative experience. An opportunity, not just to see. But really, an opportunity to live.

If we consider this notion metaphorically on a social level, it seems to me that the value of travel also provides insight into managing the extreme political polarisation in the contemporary West. The contemporary US, for example, has seen it’s two political parties both been dragged across to the extreme ends of the political ends. Many far-right Republicans have developed a distaste toward incoming immigrants and China, whilst many far-left Democrats have that same distaste, but toward the republicans themselves. It seems to me then that the “us versus them” dynamic is at it’s most feverish tipping point. What we lack however, is the shared experience. Where once the left and right shared the empowering vision of

liberalism to uphold the individual, both sides of extreme politics have devolved into narrower, collectivist mindsets. In fact, it's arguable that the left and right have never shared less than they currently do. Perhaps what we need is to travel. Not physically to other countries and continents, but socially. Travelling, on a social level, would entail a level of understanding and hearing of the opposing viewpoints. If the far-right can hear the plight of the disadvantaged, and the far-left can hear the plight of the patriotic nationalist - we may be able to strike some common ground. Many of us, we live in our tents. We live in our groups. We live, isolated. Yet if we can just venture out, into the proverbial wilderness and just see what's on the other side. Maybe therein lies a unified, peaceful world.

To travel is to get out of your natural habitat and see the world for what it is. A land of diversity, differences, and disparity. Cultures in the 21st century are products of thousands of years of development and thus venturing overseas into these lands can offer an enjoyable experience in tourism. Yet we should also consider the wider potential that travel can hold in creating unity if we truly want to see a world in harmony and peace. Not just physically, but even socially, travelling into lands unknown can help us see and share in a common experience. And whilst, for 11 years, I saw only the boundless plains to share of Australia - I had not seen anything else. I was narrow-minded and closed off from what travel and other cultures had to offer. Today I stand proud of not only my Indian heritage, but my upbringing in Australia. A shared appreciation for the two cultures that have shaped me. And it was in travel that I learned that India was not just a 3rd world country from where my grandparents had left to pursue a greater life. It was a world of wondrous food, rhythmic music, and amazing ancient architecture. The Incredible India.

Youth

“Mummy please, just one more game?”

Whilst the darkness grew outside, the day felt like it was only getting started. I was only 8 and had school the next day. And so, at 9pm, my mum was desperate for me to climb into bed and sleep. Like any other 9-year-old on a school night. But it was my second night with my brand-new Gameboy. Curled up, lying on my stomach next to the Powerwall in my bedroom so that it could charge, I had no desire to get up. It’s funny how a small portable gaming device, that today holds no comparison to the consoles of the modern electronic era, can bring you so much joy. The \$5000 PCs and PS5s of today seemingly can never fill that nostalgia I still, today, treasure. But back then, even the tiny, blurry pixels captivated me like nothing else. I think back to times like these with fondness and a gut-wrenching sadness. It’s nostalgia, they tell me. But I think it’s grief. Grief for the death of my childhood. Grief of the death of my innocence. Grief for the death of my freedom.

In reminiscing on stories like these, I’m reminded of how individuals often recall memories of youth with fondness, not just because it was ‘more fun’, but rather because age and maturity deprives us of the freedom and naive curiosity we once had. We are, most of us, just mere creatures who yearn for the days where the responsibilities and struggles of adulthood were not at the forefront of our minds. As children, we bear little responsibility for the ongoings of our lives. A toddler who poops their pants cries not out of shame or a recognition they have broken some ‘social rule’ not to poop, but purely out of discomfort. Mummy will clean my nappy and then I’ll be comfortable. No consideration for mummy, nor any

consideration for bearing responsibility to not poop my pants again. Historically we've treated children with this kind of reverence due to their inexperience in the world and their physical and intellectual in capabilities to care for themselves. This is echoed in the works of 17th century philosopher Jean Jacques Rousseau who discusses, in his treatise *Emile*, the inherent morality of the 'babe'. Yet as we look back at these days, it seems to me that what we yearn is not a Gameboy. It's not the actual activities, gadgets or toys we may miss. But rather it's the ability to indulge in such pleasures without the constant reminders from the wider world about our adult responsibilities. No phone call from our partners demanding attention and reassurance. No calendar reminders for our next University lecture. And no pressure to go work and earn a living. But as children, it's all taken care for. When I consider these ideas I'm reminded how in wider Western society, the obsession with capital accumulation and wealth generation can pulverise the inner child in us. This inner child is characterised by our desire to play, to curiously explore or to learn. Yet in a generation where young adults who play video games are considered 'time-wasters' and those who mindlessly work on professional development are appraisingly upheld as 'hustlers', we punish individuals for channelling their inner child. Mutating from Modern liberalism into an economically obsessed 'Neoliberalism' in the late 20th century, Western philosophy now reverently upholds the educated prosperous individual as the paragon for success. Yet we must observe how in reaching states of career and academic success, labour competition punishes the individual that would rather spend Tuesday night leisurely watching a documentary and rewards the individual that neglects relationships and a playful curiosity

to work. We are, most of us, dopamine junkies. And in a world where our next hit comes in the form of more money, career progression and wealth, we are at risk of overdosing into a state of nothingness. Yet even just a microdose of innocence, naivety and curiosity could take us to Nirvana.

To age is to grow and of course this naturally brings with it an opportunity to gain knowledge and maturity about our world and relationships. We grow wiser and develop as people. Yet so often we like to cling to and reminisce on those memories of what it was to be a child. Of what it was to live without burdening

responsibilities and social pressures to earn, earn, earn. But it seems unlikely that a society so obsessed with economic vitality could encourage, let alone reward a sense of childlike curiosity. Yet, if we can acknowledge and share in each other's stories of the nostalgic wonders of our childhood selves, we bring to light an existential question. We feel happier in our childlike shoes, don't we? Yet we insist on this grey and mundane adult existence. Why? We can spend 10 hours a day on Excel. Can't we spend just a few hours with our Gameboys instead?

Fantasy & Comfort

The sweet scent of the roasted hot chocolate swelled inside me.

It was a Sunday afternoon and I lay there on my slightly rusted brown leather couch in my Oodie, with my roasted hot chocolate in one hand. In the other, an old, wrinkled, and bent copy of *The Hobbit*. Before I knew it seconds turned to minutes, minutes to hours and day to night. My phone, left back in my bedroom, was buzzing off with notifications every few minutes. My friends were panicking of course. The next day was our first HSC English exam. But whilst they were scurrying through past exams, practise essays and notes – I let myself wonder into the all too familiar and comfortable world of Middle Earth. A world that I visit frequently. And a world that teaches me new things every time I visit.

The significance of this story is in its ability to convey the way in which often times comfort and familiarity are the necessary precepts to facilitate achievement. “You need to get out of your comfort zone”. In personal development circles, this kind of statement has almost become a truism. That we need to place ourselves in challenging, confronting situations has now become the default mantra for those drinking the self-improvement cool aide. And whilst encountering the unknown can offer us perspectives we’ve never considered and thus enlighten our minds; this does seem to me to be the only option for self-growth. To be comfortable means to lower our guards and stand naked to what is around us. It offers the opportunity for us to reveal to those with whom we feel comfortable, our true self. And thus, we find it easy to fart around our siblings, people with whom we’ve grown up together with and feel immensely comfortable around. Yet we dare not even use the word ‘fart’ around colleagues, acquaintances or with the girl you just

started dating last week. We use euphemisms instead to skirt around the awkwardness of the word, let alone the act itself. Of course, the filtering of our behaviour around those with whom we don't feel completely at home with is an important function in mediating sociable relations with those around us. But truly, it holds us back from being who we are. And it's in those places where we can set down the facades, we put up for the wider world that real "self-development" can come from. It comes as no surprise to me therefore that we often consider our most insightful and ground-breaking thoughts in the shower. With no one around, just our naked bodies sheltered from the rest of the world. For me this place of comfort came with a book in hand, specifically Tolkien's writing which so majestically transports me from the often-overwhelming life of a twenty-something year old in contemporary Western societies. Fantastical worlds that we encounter in literature, art and video games allow us to live the lives of vicarious and fictional characters thus disarming us of the constant paranoia of how our behaviour affects our social standing, status, and perception in the minds of others. We can live the journeys and lives of characters which truly echo our true selves. And it's only when we set aside the specially crafted façade that we build up for our real-world society that begin to learn and develop. From a place of comfort and familiarity.

Placing this in the context of wider society, it seems that citizens of the contemporary West are truly yearning for a world of comfort and familiarity. Thus, effective political propaganda creates fantastical utopias within which individuals feel an inherent sense of comfort, to galvanise their voter bases. Trump recognised that the scarred conservative American

population were constantly on edge and concerned about the incoming immigration, particularly from Latin America. Thus, his campaign in 2016 rested on bringing conservative Americans back to a USA that they felt comfortable. Hence the slogan, "make America great again". So, it seems to me that despite the widespread notion that we can only achieve and progress when placed in challenging and confronting situations, individuals are inherently yearning for a state of comfort and familiarity. It seems that whilst our external mantras may say otherwise, our actions are guided for internal mental processes that are inaccessible to our consciousness, what Sigmund Freud termed "Conscious Unconscious", is con-

stantly aware of it. Being settled invites our true rationality to speak. It's where we make some of our best decisions. It's where we belong.

Whether it comes through escaping into the world of a fictional, fantasy world or shooting down hundreds of enemies in a session of Call of Duty, we all find our places of comfort in different places. It's in enjoying these hobbies and pastimes that we disarm ourselves and set down the heavy fences that we masquerade around the world in. Some may continue to cite the ever so common saying of the importance of being outside our comfort zones and others, like myself, may disagree. Yet so long as we can recognise that fantastical worlds offer an unguarded and less tense experience as the real world which accelerates at 100 miles per hour, we can grow to appreciate these moments of solitude, familiarity, and comfort. Come with me. Let me show you my place of comfort. Meet Bilbo, meet the dwarves and meet Gandalf. These are not just characters in a book. They are my friends. They are my family.

Love

“Bro, you’re being a prick”. It stung me from head to toe.

Joe, my best friend, was typically known in our friend circle as being an open book. He’d once even told our principal he lost his virginity at the age of 15. Frisky guy. I’d always thought that a best friend was supposed to be that guy that made you laugh harder than anyone else. Someone to kick back and have a few drinks with on a humid Sunday afternoon at the local pub. Someone to go watch the footy with. But at this moment, I wanted to drive my knuckles straight into his jaw. “Rohan, I’m telling you. Go back and apologise. You’re being a prick”. Truthfully, he called me much worse names that even I can’t write down here comfortably. He was telling me to apologise to my girlfriend, Tanya. A small, throwaway comment about my tendency to prefer watching the football over date nights and I lashed out in a tirade. I was wrong, of course. But in that very moment, the last thing I wanted to hear was how wrong I was. I knew it, but in the same way we often cringe at the thought of asking for forgiveness, I was adamant not to concede to Tanya. But that’s Joe for you. Sometimes, he’ll say the exact, precise thing you least want to hear. And you want to knock the bloke out. Later, however, you also realise how much you love the guy.

This tense encounter with Joe has illuminated to me a truly loving relationship, whether romantic or platonic, requires an element of crude honesty and criticism that facilitates real individual growth. Naturally, we all want to hear the compliments and the nice words. They stroke our ego in the way that seemingly confirms to us how special and successful we are. Yet it’s often the people who don’t love, in the traditional sense, that tend to offer these affirmations. Win an

award for ‘best employee of the month’, and the colleagues you rarely speak to are there to offer their congratulations in mass. Tell your best friend, and he’ll look at you for half second, take a swig of his bubbling beer and tell you, “Mate, you could be working at a company twice the size of this one. No wonder you’re winning awards”. It appears to me that to love someone is something more than to just appreciate or like that person. It’s to have a vested interest and concern for the person and a genuine interest to see that person spread their wings and fly. We argue most, not with Sarah from sales, but with our parents. With our partners. With our friends. To love someone is to vicariously enjoy their highs and painfully suffer the lows. Standing there with his hands on hips and his deadpan expression, Joe was unimpressed. He was, as he later told me, appalled. But not because he was some bastion of moral supremacy. Not because he was the ethics police. But because he knew I was wrong. He knew I loved Tanya. He knew that I knew I was wrong. And of course, he loved me.

Stretching this narrative more broadly, it appears to me that contemporary politics invites an emphasis on a kind of fake love and compassion rather than difficult yet needed confrontation. Whether it be Anthony Albanese calling for love and compassion for the Indigenous Australian community, or Donald Trump demonstrating an understanding of the plight of rural America. Today, politicians talk to us from a place of platitudes. It’s one of the tools that makes their artful propaganda so masterfully manipulative. But this rhetoric often turns out to be simply symbolic and just said for the purpose of political signalling. Virtue

signalling, as it’s often referred to. It wins cheap votes. Yet truthfully, this often detracts from the more difficult action that is required to enact change for those in need of this ‘love’. It’s not as sexy as the propaganda. Not as sexy as Joe hyping me up.

Identity

“I’m not Grandad. I’m not Great-Grandad. And I’m not you.”

I can’t do it anymore Mum. I’m dropping out”, I choked. The words were stuck like glue in my throat for what felt like hours before they finally came out. She sat there, deadpan, before turning away. Slowly, she rose from her chair, with the grace that only she could embody and turned slightly. Blankly, she stared into the white ceramic wall of her office. My heart leapt and bounced. Yet she kept still. Like life had just pressed paused on the nightmare I was living in that moment. “So what else will you do?” she demanded. As if being a lawyer was the only job that existed. But that was her. It was her life. Wrinkle-free white business shirt, tucked into sleek black trousers. Work from home or work at the office. Mum was always dressed for the occasion. “Lawyers have standards” she says.

I dreamed of Law School for at least the five years before I was 18. It was in the family. Mum, her dad and his dad were all practising barristers, and it became a family trademark. I vicariously lived through the characters in shows like the Good Wife and Suits. To march into a courtroom with the swagger of Harvey Specter or any overly confident attorney. But I knew from the end of my first year, when I emerged from the trenches. The trenches of my Tort Law exam. I should’ve felt bliss and joy. 1/5 years, 20% of my law degree done. Triumph. Right? But as I stumbled out of that musty examination hall, it started to strike me. This wasn’t me.

It took me a whole other year to make the decision to change degrees. It was hard. I had tied my identity to being a law student. The pressure cooker, hyper-competitive Indian culture that I lived in assured me that my value as a 18 and 19

year old was validated by my degree. “Here’s Rohan, he’s studying Law at USYD,” said my parents, close relatives, and grandparents. That’s how they’d introduce me to the wider community. Not, “Here’s Rohan, he was the captain of his school last year” or “Here’s Rohan, he volunteers every Sunday at the Gurudwara (Sikh Temple)”. Sure, those labels came later. But it was first and foremost a declaration of my academic prestige that would fill my closest family with pride and joy. And thus I lived up to the validation. I bought a Jumper from the USYD Law Society. I once even wore it to my uncle’s house for dinner. I still cringe at that. I believed the hype. I had won the prestige game. But I was losing the others. It was difficult at first, but once the fake praise stopped I started value myself in a different way. Sure, my parents no longer boasted me studying a ‘mere’ Commerce degree. But now my spiritual endeavours and reverence did become a topic of conversation. And whilst it may not have impressed the wider community as much, I was much prouder of it. It wasn’t a label of who I might become. It was me today. I spent the remaining 2 years of my university life much happier. Studying Commerce, a field I was significantly more passionate about filled me with excitement and galvanised me to actively participate in other parts of my life like societies and spirituality. I felt a significant shift in the meaningfulness of each waking day, echoing the sentiment of Danish philosopher Soren Kierkegaard who said, “Life’s meaning comes from its present experience”. I lived in the moment. I enjoyed each day. I didn’t dread every lecture. Every tutorial. Every exam. A future lawyer no more.

The significance of this story is that it illuminates the limiting way in which individuals in the contemporary West tie their identity purely to economic value and career. This kind of sentiment has grown strongly out of the unbridled, neoliberal capitalism since the mid-20th century. Catalysed by mass deregulation and a Thatcherian, reverent focus on markets by governments, the Western world has become a society that is obsessed with economic vitality. Thus consumerism and the ever-present quest for ‘more’ has become ubiquitous, with advertisements surrounding us everywhere. On TV. On YouTube. On Radio. And so, throughout our lifecycle, wealth generation and economic success become our primary aim. We study at school not to develop as morally sound human beings, as Jean-

Jacques Rousseau encouraged, but rather for the functional value of high scores to earn entry to prestigious universities. So it appears that our focus is on fulfilling the neoliberal, consumerist dream and not one of personal fulfillment. We once lived in a world where the priest received as much if not more recognition and validation as the lawyer. Today however, the lawyer is perceived as the embodiment of success; an embodiment of hustle culture and an embodiment of a valuable member to society. The priest meanwhile has been pushed aside as just a ‘vocation’ that one might take up if other options to study are unattainable. We are cash junkies. And we’re all after the next hit.

“Be like Rohan, see how he gets such good marks” they would say to their children when pointing at me. It felt nice. But it was shallow. It was covering the cracks and when I let it all go and studied what I wanted, the proverbial weight flew off my shoulders. My identity became tied to me as an individual, not to my career aspirations. Yet I empathise with the Indian community, and I understand why I was perceived in such high-standing. Our society feeds the individual. And as we swing around in the neoliberal whirlpool, we are getting lost. We’re forgetting what made our society what it was. True liberalism focused on the justice and morality of a society in upholding the value of the individual. Not of the consumer. So, I say to my mum. I dropped Law. I may not become like you or grandad. But I will become me. And I will make you prouder than any lawyer ever could.

Happiness

Have you ever laughed so hard, that your ribs feel like they are being crushed?

Have you ever laughed so hard, that your ribs feel like they are being crushed with every fit of laughter. So hard that every breath you take is so painful. So painful that you try not laughing, but of course that attempt to hold it in just a little longer makes you laugh even more. There was only one guy that could make me laugh like that. His name was Jai. When I was 10, my best friend Jai moved to the USA. Permanently. He said he'd be back in a "year or two". He lied. I didn't see him until I was 16, 6 years later. I'd met him in preschool, when I was 2, and for the next 8 years Jai became "my guy". He was 2 years older than me but that didn't stop us from enjoying the sizzling summer afternoons at each other's houses or even enjoying freezing cold winter nights at the park. Such happy, happy times. So could it be that the boy I platonically loved so deeply would be the one to leave me. To betray me. I remember standing there, outside his small, bricked townhouse the day before his flight. I hugged him. Gave him an awkward handshake and he was off. I stood, deadpan, as he walked back into his house. Few years isn't so bad I thought. Both our mums were crying out the corner of my right-eye. I didn't get it then. It hadn't hit me.

When I first got the news that he was moving, I wasn't sad. I was surprised, sure, but not sad. In fact, if anything, a tinge of frustration tainted my mood for the days thereafter. Frustration at his dad for accepting some job in the outskirts of LA. Frustration at Jai for agreeing to go. Of course, I now realise he had very little say but nonetheless, it was frustration before sadness. So, there I was, 10

years old and stuck. Helpless and above all, for the first time in my life I felt lonely. The next few years were difficult in that I could never find a ‘best friend’ that could replace Jai. No one made me laugh that same way. No one inspired me, in only the way a friend 2 years older than me could. A huge, Jai-shaped hole was left gaping through my stomach. It was at this point that my frustration turned into a internal monologue. “Why even become friends with Jai in the first place”. If only I’d invested in developing a real friendship with those my age, I’d have a different best friend. One that wouldn’t just leave me one day, not to return for six years.

When I look back at how a distressed, 10-year-old version of myself reacted to this situation I do empathise with him a little. Yet what I do regret looking back on my friendship with Jai in disdain. The sudden disruption to our friendship prompted me not to treasure those memories we had made as kids, but rather wish they never even happened in the first place. The sadness of the hole he left in my heart overwhelmed the irreplaceable place he had and will always have there. I could’ve and should’ve been more optimistic. And after a while, as I aged a bit more and had access to social media, we remained in touch via video call and Instagram. It wasn’t so bad. Certainly not bad enough to replace those memories we created.

This story illustrates to me how in the contemporary West, we are too concerned with the endpoint of our happiness. We often live in state of dread and pessimism as it feels only inevitable that a happy memory will dissipate, only to be replaced by the tiresome reality. The last day of the weekend is not filled with joy and relaxation, but rather a overwhelming dread for work on Monday morning. And on a more macro level, the end of our youth is not met with an excitement to capitalise on the next stage of our adult lives, but rather a poignant

realisation that we are ageing. It seems to me that in the contemporary neoliberal West, our lives have been overcome with this underlying sense of mundanity and inevitability. Vacations are a ticking time-bomb before we return back to work. This need to work and earn, often in forms which are not enjoyable but rather repetitive and uninteresting for many, often takes away from our ability to enjoy the present. But to feed our Heideggerian *dasein* or “inner being”, the abili-

ty to be happy and enjoy the present should exist without the dread of returning to our mechanical lives.

12 years on, and I look back on that evening before Jai's flight with a strange sense of nostalgia. In fact, I laugh at how emotionless and deadpan I was. Naturally of course, my 10 year old self did not immediately grasp the significance of the moment. But eventually I did. And when it hit me, I responded with a sort of childish frustration which, while I do still somewhat sympathise with, focused on the wrong thing. I was focused on the sadness and frustration to come, with my best friend living on the other side of the world. And in turn, I discarded the childhood I'd had, filled with happiness and laughter. It seems to me that this remains an underlying concern in wider contemporary society. A feeling of dread and mundanity of our short-term future, detracts from the times of happiness we have. Those last few weeks with Jai, before he moved were awkward. There was a definitive end to our friendship we thought. But today, I sit with him, beer in hand and lying on a beach chair and once again we laugh. We laugh until we crush our ribs. But really it doesn't hurt.

Laughter

All the world's a stage, as Shakespeare put it.

Except this time, I was actually on a stage. I had always been good at putting up an act. At putting up a facade. Of being someone, I was not. So naturally, I took up Drama at school and by Year 12 - I had picked up a lead role in a promising play at a nearby theatre. Here I was. Years in the making. Years of training and rehearsing. Here I was playing the lead in front of over 1,000 in the audience. And despite my best confidence, on opening night I flopped. Badly. In the opening scene, I tripped whilst walking across stage and that began a string of mishaps. I forgot my line in the third scene. Forgot two lines in the fifth scene. And in the final scene, I lost control of the prop gun and it fell right into the lap of a spectator in the first row. I knew it. The audience knew it. The rest of the cast knew it. I flopped. And as the night grew darker and darker, they laughed, and they teased. Or at least, that's how I imagined it in my mind.

That I had made several mistakes that night was inarguable. I knew it. And it hurt. Theatre is a team game. You win together. You lose together. It was this realisation which hurt me that night as I tossed and turned trying to get to sleep. Oh, how I wanted to sleep. But it kept me awake all night.

The High School version of myself could connect most of his actions and motivations to one motivator. To be viewed by others impressionably. Whether it was my desire to perform on a soccer field. Or my desire to score a great ATAR. Or my desire to nail a performance as a lead actor. It all came down to my fixation on being viewed in a positive way in the eyes of others. And when the achievements came, they felt meaningless without the heaps of appraisal from family and

friends. I felt nothing. I had always been told I would be a good actor. I had always felt that. But that night, my greatest strength created my biggest embarrassment. Yet somewhere I knew it wasn't the failure that hurt most. What hurt most was imagining how others would no longer see me impressably as a stellar actor. A star no more.

The reality was that most people didn't really care. An audience member may have had a fleeting moment of second-hand cringe or ridicule during the performance. But each audience member has their own struggles. Their own challenges. Their own life. I had built up such a strong narrative in my mind about how much everyone would care and criticise me for making mistakes. But the truth was that people are too selfish to truly care about me for that long.

Looking back now I'm able to recognise that tendency of my high school self seeking validation and approval from others. My identity was not, Wayne the good-hearted son, brother, or grandson. No, my identity was much shallower. It was tied up into being defined by not who I was, but what I achieved. To be honest, it soaked dry a lot of the joys high school had to offer. I sacrificed much too much to perfect my acting and study. I truly believe that this rigid seriousness held me back more than embracing my vulnerabilities would've. I was so determined to achieve that I missed the biggest chance to do so. To learn and embrace

my vulnerabilities. To sit back and laugh at myself. It could've given me flexibility to learn. To grow. To adapt.

Expanding wider, it seems to me that in the contemporary West, individuals miss the opportunity to take their shortfalls lightly and grow from them. As our world becomes evermore obsessed with capital accumulation and career progression we are not afforded the opportunity to laugh at ourselves. Instead, every step we take must be perfect. We are defined socially by our achievement. Naturally, it seems to me this is because we can see each other on the surface-level. Hence the most successful household on the street is not the happiest and most content. But rather the family with the biggest house. We only see the facade. This creates an insidious feedback loop where the ambition to accumulate wealth and achieve career progression become the only markers of success. This neoliberal version of

the West thus breeds an unhealthy level of economic competition, where individuals are often purely motivated by the desire to superseed their peers. A mistake at work or a mishap at university is thus not seen as a valuable experience to learn from, but instead as a critical event that can send an individual into economic catastrophe. How can we laugh in such an unforgiving, ruthless social structure? It seems the capitalist world we live in in the contemporary West is a paragon for what the Buddha condemned. With his symbolic image, constantly in laughter, the Buddha warned of a world overcome by the pursuit of excess which would debilitate our ability to enjoy life. Enjoy life beyond excess. Enjoy life with laughter.

Too many of us are like my high school self. Incapable of looking past our moments of embarrassment, misfortune and error due to an overwhelming pressure to strive for perfection in the eyes of others. In the contemporary West, individuals are similarly placed in positions where mistakes and errors made cannot be looked upon with reminsence and an opportunity to grow. One error at work or mistake at school can send an individual plaguing at the bottom of the socioeconomic ladder. We measure the success of an individual based on their career progression and education attainment - thus building an incredible pressure to perform in these areas. But if we tune down the pressure just a bit, what we find is that opportunities to grow and develop as people and spiritually are being forgone in our attempt to abide by this capitalist machine. And yet today I look back at that awful performance. And I see myself sitting with everyone else in the theatre. Sitting with the audience. And together, we laugh at the actor.

Food

“Go son. Just don’t drop it though”. It was at least 20 kilos.

If not 200. And I was just 13. You could argue that it was some kind of divine intervention, from Guru Nanak himself, that gave me the capacity to carry the pot. It was Sunday morning, and that meant Seva (or ‘service’ in English) at my local Gurudwara, the Sikh temple. Only in Sikhism’s Seva, do you have a hall filled with hundreds of religious adherents, poor and rich, who sit humbly on the floor with the community to eat. And volunteers who take part in Seva have roles from cooking, cleaning the kitchen and serving the food to the hundreds. Since I can remember, mum had always pushed me to get involved with Seva. Whilst she was always with a few other women preparing the food, children like me served the food; fresh flatbread, creamy curries, and delicious desserts. And as I pushed my down the hall which, back then felt like the length of ten football pitches, I felt a warmth on the faces of those sitting down awaiting the meal that radiated through me.

Whilst I no longer volunteer in Seva, I do often drive into the Gurudwara on Sunday mornings to take it all in again. It is true, that back then, as a child I didn’t fully get why mum made such a big deal for it. Sure, it was nice to see hundreds of men and women kindly accept the curry that I poured from a pan which felt larger than my own 13-year-old self. But beyond that it felt arbitrary. “Why can’t we just eat our own food”, I’d ask mum often. “Why do we have to sit on the floor? Tables exist don’t they?”

For mum, Seva had been part of her own cultural upbringing in India. I think what she tried to get out of having me involved with the volunteering of Seva

from day one was two-fold. Firstly, I think mum saw it as an opportunity to humble me and accentuate the value of food. Seeing those from a low socioeconomic background share the same, wide smiles as the economic elites showed me how food could unite us. On top of that, mum definitely saw my involvement in Seva as an opportunity to inculcate me into my religious and cultural communities. And that it did. Serving food to hundreds of people meant that I had to learn how to communicate with them. English, Hindi or Punjabi. I can certainly attribute my trilingual capabilities to community involvements like Seva. But moreover, the food itself was symbolic of our culture - with us all enjoying the very meals that our ancestors once did. The very meals that outside the Gurudwara, are much harder to find and indulge in. “Naan from the Gurudwara just hits different”, my cousin used to say.

Looking back today however, there’s something about a communal meal that strikes as particularly poignant. Food (and water) is, arguably, the single most important thing for human survival. We can, technically, survive without shelter. Tribes have done for thousands of years. But food is something that ties the human experience together. The forefathers of Sikhism recognised this and thus incorporated a communal meal as part of religious practise. Regardless of our ethnicity, faith, sociocultural background or anything else - we all need food. The communal meal at Seva functions as a sort of cultural reset. For those that make the effort to attend, you’re sat in a room with hundreds of people that you not only have never met, but come from vastly different backgrounds. And in a society today where the neoliberal

hunger (pun intended) for wealth and profits distracts from what our authentic, inner self truly thirsts for - communal dining in this way strikes me as spiritual retreat. In the context of wider Western society, it seems to me that we are increasingly separating the utilitarian benefit of food from its wider potential. Amidst our distracted lives where the rampant commodification and intense capitalist competition governs us, we treat food as merely a means to the end. It’s just fuel. Corporate lunches are not organised for the sake of partaking in a meal together, but rather for an overarching interest in networking. To this extent, it could be said that Food is a status symbol. When we do this however, our inner

self, the Heideggerian ‘dasein’ suffers and loses out on the wider social and cultural benefits that food can bring. Being that underlying thread that ties us together, the eating of food once brought us boundless meaning and satisfaction. Beyond just Sikhism, the ‘breaking of the bread’ and ‘last supper’ are still upheld are tenets of the Christian story. Communion, through the ingestion of bread and wine still exist in the Christian tradition to communally invite all adherents to eat and drink the ‘body and blood of Christ’. But now, food is not eaten. It’s consumed. This term encapsulates how, without cognisance, food has been transported into the commodified, economic realm. History has much to teach us, but the ontological benefits of food is a lesson which must cling to.

Food is, of course to some extent, just a tool for survival. But assuming we transcend the state where food is so scarce, it has taken a cultural and spiritual form in many nations around the world; West and East. Yet it seems today, distracted by the capitalist game, food has been drilled down into a commodity and a mere means to an end. For me, the communal meals I partake in as a Sikh give me a temporary retreat from this neoliberal world that surrounds us in the West. The pot might’ve been 20 kilograms, but to know your feeding the mouths of hundreds, it feels like a mere feather.

Forgiveness

My hero became the villain.

Dad was always my go to answer for those typical, “who’s your hero” questions in primary school. But a week out from my 18th birthday, as my wailing mother ran out of the house with tears flooding our tiled floors, I stormed into my parents room to find my ‘hero’ standing - with his hands clasped behind his back staring aimlessly into the ceramic wall. He didn’t move. Mum had uncovered his secreting. His \$3.5 million secret. A secret of horses and cards. A secret of gambling. In a blind pursuit of greed, money and the conceptualisation of ‘more’ - my hero had gambled everything he and our entire family had owned. His savings, Mum’s savings, my grandparent’s Super and even mine and my sister’s fraught savings of just a few thousand dollars. All gone.

Interestingly, Mum was the first to forgive Dad. Well, it was interesting to me then but now it makes a lot more sense. What I learned over the few months following the revelation of his ‘secret’ and the consequential sale of my childhood home, cars and all family assets that with it, was that my family around me needed Dad. Not for his breadwinning. But more so for their own inner peace. I didn’t speak to Mum for 2 months in my fury of how she could forgive Dad. She was a coward I thought. “Go out and make something of yourself”, I thought. Why on earth would you forgive, this man. “This man”. Not even Dad anymore. But it was Mum’s need for security in the love and presence of others that overcame any feelings of distrust she may have had. She forgave him.

It was not so easy for me however. I could not forgive him for at least a year, and when I did - I didn’t feel it coming from the heart. I forgave him because of

others, but not really for myself. Our family household, in a house a tenth of the size of the mansion we once lived in, was fractured primarily due to my raging fury toward him. Ultimately, it became too much for both Mum and my sister and I forgave him. Yet whilst I did think I deserved peace from this hatred I harboured, I did not get it. Instead, a lingering feeling of bitterness remained. In fact, it still remains. I think it's because in forgiving my Dad, I have had to, as a byproduct, accept certain values about the family nucleus that I just couldn't. Forgiving him meant moving on from the trauma he had brought our entire family. Forgiving him meant accepting that selfishly bringing about the entire family's downfall was okay in the end. So as he never really apologised for me, stuck up in his egotistic maintenance that the 18 years of providing me overrode any mistakes that could have possibly been made thereafter, I could never really forgive him. The real forgiveness that Mum and my sister sought from me was one that required me to accept the past - but more deeply, accept that enough had been done by Dad to rectify it. To that extent, peace from forgiving others has to derive from a genuine apology from the one asking for forgiveness.

To that extent, in wider society, it seems that my own struggles in forgiving my father echo the dissatisfaction that many marginalised groups continue to harbour against our supposed 'liberal' democracies. It is true that today in the 21st century, governments across our Western democracies have all but eliminated discrimination from the legal realm. The Mabo

case in the late 1990s in Australia, revoked the legal designation of 'Terra Nullius' and upheld the historical truth of Indigenous occupation of Australian land for thousands of years prior in legal precedent. Yet despite a verbal apology from Kevin Rudd in his 2008 'Sorry' speech, enough has not been done to rectify the crimes of the Stolen Generation and assimilation of the past. It therefore strikes me as completely plausible that Indigenous Australians continue to harbour a distrust toward the establishment as their forgiveness of the past is not really felt from the heart. Real forgiveness requires a satisfaction that action is being made to rectify the past and not just empty words. Without redemptive action, the Heideggerian 'dasein' or authentic self will never be able to truly forgive. The structural inequality and related lack of opportunity that has arisen from en-

trenched discrimination means that our Indigenous people cannot forgive and live in peace, for the crimes of the past are still being felt. Action to address educational and welfare concerns and ensure that such people have equal access to opportunity would be a telling first step toward a genuine apology that may yield a true and heartfelt forgiveness.

To forgive and forget is not as possible as the phrase simplistically implies. Rather, our 'dasien' does not forget - as our emotional state is intertwined with the impacts of the past. To simply suggest that letting go of the past and moving on yields inner peace is also too simplistic as it assumes we can flick a proverbial switch and reset our 'dasien'. Yet what we find is that real forgiveness, the kind that does induce peace for both ourselves and those around us, can only come from a rectification of the past. I've tried rebuilding my relationship with my Dad and whilst it's not as antagonistic as it once was, it's nowhere near perfect. Until I feel, as his son, that he genuinely attempts to rectify the family trauma he caused, that peace will never come. And my hero will remain dead, as the villain roams free.

